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The Modern Husband's Guide To Wife Sharing: Part One

Paul Garland

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Foreword

Dear Reader,

Thank you so much for purchasing "The Modern Husband's Guide To Becoming A Cuckold - Part One." I wanted to explore what happens when a young married couple like Jordan and Daisy discover desires they never knew existed, hidden beneath the surface of their seemingly ordinary suburban life. This first volume establishes the foundation for Jordan's journey into fantasies he's barely admitted to himself, while introducing the secrets of Far Bridge Rise that will change everything.

I hope you enjoy reading this as much as I enjoyed writing it. If you do, please consider leaving a review on whichever platform you purchased from. Your feedback means the world to independent authors like me. And keep an eye out for Part Two, coming out in November, where things get much more intense!

Thanks again for buying and reading the book,

Paul

Chapter one

Chapter 1: The New Neighbours

One moment, we were unpacking groceries from the boot of our car: bags of fresh vegetables, Daisy's favourite coffee, and food to fill up the freezer. The next moment, chaos exploded in the quiet cul-de-sac where we lived.

I was stacking bags on the porch when a sudden bark cut through the afternoon's peacefulness. A beautiful Weimeraner, all silvery coat and bright eyes, darted out from behind a parked car across the street. Its leash trailed behind it, clearly having slipped from the jogging owner's hand: a woman with vibrant red hair pulled back in a ponytail, curvy yet clearly fit, as evidenced by her tight running wear.

"Oh no, Bluebell!" she called out, but it was too late.

Before any of us could react, the dog bolted straight onto the street. A car, pulling too fast off its drive, screeched to a halt, veering onto the path to avoid the animal.

And that's when everything spiralled out of control.

The car clipped a figure — a young woman on a bicycle - who lost her balance and skidded sideways onto the asphalt, her arms flailing, landing hard on one elbow. A sharp cry broke the stunned silence.

The driver slammed the brakes and jumped out, and at the same time, I dropped the shopping bags with a curse, my heart hammering, and ran over to help.

"Are you okay?" I asked as I crouched beside the stricken young woman, who had managed to push herself to a sitting position on the kerb.

She winced, brushing dust from her scraped elbow, but managed a rueful smile. Even shaken and dusty, she was striking. She had olive skin, dark eyes, and long, dark hair escaping from her cycling helmet, probably in her early twenties and clearly very fit. "I think so. Just... that hurt like hell. I'm Kendall."

"Jordan," I replied. "Let me take a look at that elbow."

From behind, the jogger appeared, breathless and panicked, the Weimeraner now safely on its leash. The woman was probably in her early thirties, curvy but athletic, and her green eyes were wide with worry. "I'm so sorry! I'm Corinne. I live at number one. Bluebell's usually so good, but he saw a squirrel and just bolted."

Kendall looked up at her, pain mixing with understanding. "It's okay. These things happen. At least your dog's alright."

The bike was half-lodged in a shrub, and I pulled it free, giving it a quick scan. The paintwork was slightly scratched, but both wheels were intact. I turned back towards Kendall and checked her over, too. She looked fine, mostly. No blood was visible except from the grazed elbow, and as I helped her to her feet, there didn't seem to be any broken bones or other injuries. By some stroke of luck, everyone was okay.

The driver finally walked over to us, and I found myself looking at a handsome man in his early forties. His hair was prematurely greying, as was the stubble on his chin, and he was well-built with striking blue eyes. His voice was steady but shaken. "I'm Alex. I was just visiting my friend. Is everyone okay? That dog came out of nowhere."

I nodded. "Looks like it. Kendall's got a scrape and probably some bruising, but nothing serious."

Alex pulled out his phone. "I'm really sorry about this. If anyone needs anything, whatever, here's my number." He handed me a business card. I offered it to Kendall, and she slid it into the pocket of her tight cycling shorts.

"Hey. Our house is right here, we were just bringing in the groceries. Why don't you both come in?" Daisy appeared beside me, ever the hostess. "Kendall, we should clean that elbow properly, and Alex, you look like you could use a cup of tea."

Corinne checked her watch. "I should get Bluebell home before she causes any more mischief. Kendall, I'm so sorry again. Please let me know if you need anything. I'm just at the far end at number one."

I tried not to look at Corinne's shapely backside as she jogged away with the excitable grey dog. Alex helped us gather the last few bags of groceries while Kendall walked her bike slowly toward our front door. "That's really kind of you," she said to Daisy. "But I only live there," she pointed up the road. "At number fourteen with my family, so we're neighbours."

"Hello, neighbour," Daisy smiled, then shook her head, her long blonde hair flowing around her shoulders, "But seriously, I insist. Let me make sure you're all okay."

"Please?" I asked, my gaze switching between the two neighbours. "She'll be offended if you say no."

"Sure," Kendall nodded, Alex following suit.

"If it makes you feel better," the driver added.

Once we got everyone inside, Alex placed the last of the shopping bags on the table, but declined Daisy's offer of tea. "I promise, I'm fine. I really do need to get home. It's an hour's drive, and my kids will be wondering where I am." He shook my hand firmly, then turned to Kendall. "I really am sorry about all of this." He looked at me one final time. "Thanks for taking charge out there."

"Jordan loves being the hero," Daisy teased me, elbowing me gently in the ribs, then seeing him to the front door.

After he left, I found myself in our kitchen with Kendall, carefully cleaning her scraped elbow with antiseptic while Daisy made tea. The graze wasn't deep, but some attention didn't hurt.

"You're very kind," Kendall said, watching me work. "You're the new couple on the street, aren't you?"

"Daisy and Jordan Hoyland. We moved in a couple of weeks ago," Daisy introduced us properly, bringing over the tea. "We wanted to be closer to the university. I'm finishing my master's in psychology."

"Wow." Kendall smiled. "That's very cool. I deferred my degree for a year and never went back. I'm still figuring out what I want to study. Maybe I'll finish my education one day."

"How old are you?" I asked, applying a sticking plaster to her elbow. "All done, by the way. Take it easy on that bike for a few days."

"Twenty-one," the olive-skinned woman replied. "You guys are... what? Twenty..."

"Twenty-five," Daisy nodded. "Jordan's a year older."

"And you're married?" Kendall rolled down her sleeve, grimacing a little as she straightened her bruised arm. She looked around our tidy kitchen and living room through the open door. "No children?"

"Not yet," I nodded. "We've only been married two years."

"When the time's right, we'll start a family," Daisy added, pushing her blonde hair behind one ear, her face turning pink for some reason.

"Anyway, thanks again." As Kendall prepared to leave, she paused at our door. "I meant what I said about us being neighbours. Maybe this weekend, we could have that cup of tea without the drama. You can meet my parents. They run the local neighbourhood watch."

"That would be nice." I watched her leave, wheeling her bike down the street towards home. After she'd gone, Daisy and I stood in our hallway, looking at each other.

"Well," Daisy said, her hands on her hips, her brown eyes wide, "That's one way of getting to know some of the locals."

I glanced out the window toward the cul-de-sac, the neat lawns, the parked cars, the street back to its formerly quiet self. This was our new home, and I

had a feeling that we would be happy here. But having a good relationship with the neighbours would certainly help along the way.

Later that evening, after dinner, Daisy buried herself in her study notes. She was sitting at our dining table, laptop open, her work glasses perched on her nose, the blue glow illuminating her high cheekbones. Her fingers danced furiously on the keys, and every so often she'd sigh, rub her eyes, and mutter to herself as she read back a paragraph.

I tidied the kitchen, stacking pans, wiping surfaces, and sweeping up a few stray scraps. Not that we were messy, but it was easier to keep on top of things these days. Even back at our old place, I'd picked up the slack at home, and it felt good. Daisy was relentless, studying for her master's degree while also working as a legal assistant at a family law firm. Tomorrow, she had another early meeting, a conference call with the partners about a mediation case.

She closed her laptop before ten and stretched, arms reaching high, her T-shirt sliding up at the waist to show just a sliver of pale skin. "God, I'm shattered," she groaned, plucking off her glasses and tossing them onto the table.

I smiled from where I was, by the sink, putting the last few dishes away. "You say that every night, you know."

She grinned back. "You'd think by now my boss might actually start paying attention to my hours and giving me some time off occasionally." She pointed at me, finger wagging in a mock scold. "You'd better have my coffee ready in the morning."

I dried my hands, weaving through the kitchen towards her, catching her wrist and spinning her into my arms. "I'll have it ground fresh. The good stuff, just the way you like it."

"I don't deserve you," she whispered, her smile softening. She smelled good. She always did, even without perfume. "Seriously, I don't. Most guys would be telling me to get off my laptop and cook dinner."

I pressed a kiss to her forehead, and she breathed in deep. "Most guys aren't trying to be modern husbands."

She snorted. "Most guys wish they were half as modern as you, Jordan Hoyland. I don't say it enough." She wrapped her arms around my neck, lips close to my ear. "But I love you. I love how you are, and I wouldn't swap you for anyone in the world, even when you're acting as a hero to random women in the street. You're supposed to be my hero. No one else's."

I laughed. "I am yours, Daisy Hoyland. Always and forever."

Her hands slid down my chest, slow and warm. "Then take me to bed, Modern Husband. Before I fall asleep out here."

We didn't say much more. I pulled her gently toward our bedroom, my hand finding the small of her back, guiding her upstairs and through the doorway. I switched on the bedside lamp, casting a warm glow across the room, and when I turned to face her, Daisy was already reaching for the hem of her T-shirt.

"Let me," I whispered, catching her hands in mine.

She smiled, that soft, teasing expression that never failed to make my chest tighten with love and my dick harden with attraction. I lifted the top slowly, revealing the pale curve of her waist, the gentle swell of her breasts beneath her white T-shirt bra. Her skin was warm under my fingertips as I traced the line from her hip to her ribs.

"You're beautiful," I murmured, meaning it completely.

She stepped closer, her hands working at the buttons of my shirt, fingers nimble and sure. "Why, Mr Hoyland, you've never told me that before," she breathed against my chest as she pushed the fabric away from my shoulders.

When she reached for the clasp of her bra, I covered her hands again, drawing her against me, skin to skin. The contact sent a ripple of arousal

through us both. I could feel it in the way she gasped softly, the way her body melted into mine.

"I love you," she whispered as I finished unclasping her bra, her lips finding my neck, pressing warm kisses along my collarbone.

"I love you too," I replied, cupping her face in my hands as the bra fell away, and drawing her into a kiss that started gently but quickly deepened into hunger. Her tongue danced with mine as I walked her backwards toward the bed, never breaking the kiss. When the backs of her legs hit the mattress, she pulled away just long enough to shimmy out of her jeans and white panties, leaving her completely bare before me.

Even after two years of marriage, the sight of her naked body never failed to amaze me, and my breath caught in my throat. Her breasts were only average-sized but perfectly shaped, with dark pink nipples already hardened with anticipation. Her hips flared gently from her narrow waist, and the soft tuft of light hair between her thighs made my mouth water.

"Come here," she said, reaching for my belt buckle with eager fingers.

I helped her, stepping out of my clothes as quickly as I could manage, desperate to feel her skin against mine again. When I finally joined her on the bed, she was already reaching for my hard cock, guiding me on top of her, her legs parting in invitation.

"Make love to me," she whispered, her dark eyes heavy with desire.

I positioned myself at her entrance, feeling her warmth, her wetness as the tip of my cock nestled between her lips. "If you insist."

"Oh, I do," she whispered, wrapping her arms around my neck and pulling me down for another kiss.

I entered her slowly, savouring the way she wrapped her thighs around me, the soft moan that escaped her lips as I went all the way in. For a moment, we just held each other, breathing in unison, both of us enjoying the sensation of being together.

Then I began to move, setting a rhythm that had her arching beneath me, her hands gripping my shoulders, her breath coming in short gasps against my ear. She felt incredible as always, tight, perfect.

"Jordan," she moaned, her hips rising to meet mine, matching my pace.
"Faster."

I buried my face in her neck, breathing in her scent, losing myself in the feeling of her pussy, of making love to the woman I adored. Her body responded to mine instinctively, and I could feel her getting closer, her muscles tightening around me.

"You feel so good," I whispered, increasing my pace slightly, angling to hit that spot that I knew drove her wild. She reached down with her hand, between our bodies, finding her sensitive clit and rubbing it, pushing herself over the edge.

She cried out softly, her back arching, and I felt her climax ripple through her, her pussy pulsing around me. The sensation, combined with the look of pure bliss on her face, her eyes rolled back, pushed me over the edge. With a groan, I thrust deep one final time, spilling myself inside her as the familiar surge of pleasure crashed through me.

Afterwards, we lay tangled together, her head on my chest, both of us still breathing heavily. I stroked her golden hair, watching as her eyelids grew heavy.

"Thank you," she murmured sleepily.

"For what?"

"For being you. For loving me the way you do. For everything you do in the house." Her voice was already fading as sleep claimed her.

Within minutes, she was out completely, mouth slightly parted, her blonde hair messy against the pillow, one arm draped across my chest. I watched her sleep for a while, marvelling at how peaceful she looked, how utterly content.

I lay there for a long moment, listening to Daisy's even breathing, feeling it slow and deepen as sleep took hold. Eventually, I slipped out from beneath the tangled sheets, careful not to wake her. My jeans were still folded neatly where I'd left them, so I dug my phone out of the pocket and sank into the armchair by the window.

Daisy was exhausted tonight, but me? I wasn't tired. I enjoyed these quiet, solitary moments when she was tucked away in bed, allowing me to relax for a while before sleep.

I was as much of a news junkie and a sports fan as the next person, but I also enjoy stories and essays about modern husbands, relationship dynamics, and the push and pull of roles at home and in love. It helped me reconcile the more challenging aspects of our marriage.

Daisy was the breadwinner, the powerhouse; I was the struggling artist lucky enough to have a partner who was patient and believed in what I did. I respected that deeply, and I respected her enough to balance it by taking on the majority of the household chores—including cleaning, cooking, and any other tasks that needed to be done—things a wife might have traditionally done, but not in our marriage.

Recently, I discovered some blogs and posts written by women who have embraced a different path, the opposite of what I lived, the 'Trad Wife' path. It fascinated me to see what they believed and how they lived, the contrast to our own dynamic.

One of them in particular stood out. It was why, I had to admit, I'd been a little horny all day long. Her handle was DemureMillieGrace, and she was gorgeous. The name had popped up in my recommended feed this morning, as it often did, but today's video wasn't like any of her usual TikToks. I had watched it once already, but I searched it out as I sat in the chair by the bed, and pressed play again.

The video started the same way as many of hers did: the lovely brunette Millie chopping herbs in her kitchen while talking about what she was going to cook for dinner. And then a moment so innocent, so subtle, that I almost missed it the first time I watched. Her delicate blouse gaped open as

she turned to the side. It was brief, just a glimpse of pale breast, a flash of pink nipple, before she straightened and continued her domestic routine, completely oblivious. But it was sexy in a way that was both pure and compelling, teasing but unintentional.

Despite only having cum a short time ago, I felt my cock twitch as I watched it again, freeze-framing the video and admiring the soft curve of her tit. Millie was beautiful in her own way; that classic retro housewife look suited her, embodying tradition with a sensual grace that was undeniably attractive. But Daisy? I couldn't compare the two women. My Daisy was even prettier than Millie, blonde, fierce, independent, a career woman. She was everything I loved and admired.

The video ended, and I found myself scrolling through her blog, reading her latest posts about marriage, homemaking, and the joys of supporting her husband. Her words were thoughtful and genuine, but they painted a picture so different from our own life that it felt like glimpsing an alternate universe.

I glanced back at Daisy, sleeping peacefully in our bed, blonde hair spread across the pillow, and smiled. We were happily married, but still figuring out some things: her career, my art, our future together, and when the right time would be to start a family.

I watched Millie's post and her nipple slip one last time, then browsed the news and sports scores before setting my phone aside and getting into bed. I tried to sleep, but my mind kept wandering. What would it feel like if Daisy were ever to have a moment like that? An unintentional nip slip of her own. I'd be turned on, I knew I would. The thought of other men seeing her naked always sent an unexpected thrill through me.

An even bigger fantasy, though — the one I could never voice to her — was wondering what it would be like if she were with someone else. Not leaving me, not betraying our marriage, but her sleeping with someone else, with my permission or knowledge. The thought of her with another man was a huge turn-on, one that made my pulse quicken and my body respond in ways I couldn't quite explain.

She'd had two boyfriends before me, two lovers before we first dated, and I often found myself fantasising about what they were like, how they made her cum, what sounds she made when they were inside her. But whenever I tried to bring it up, even casually, she'd shut it down. She wasn't into that kind of talk. Those relationships were in the past, and she preferred to keep them there.

So I kept my little fetish to myself, this secret desire that felt both thrilling and shameful. We were married now. We'd made vows to be faithful to each other, to forsake all others. Those weren't just words; they were promises we'd both meant when we spoke them. Daisy especially took those vows seriously, given what her mother's infidelity had done to her family.

I glanced back at her sleeping form, feeling a mixture of love and frustrated longing. She was everything to me, but there was this part of my desires that would always remain hidden, locked away in fantasies and the occasional late-night browsing sessions like this one. It would always be my secret, always remain just a fantasy.

Maybe that was for the best. Some desires were meant to stay buried, weren't they? Some thoughts were too dangerous to share, too risky to explore in real life. Our marriage was strong, our love was real, and that had to be enough.

But what if the opportunity arose? What if circumstances somehow aligned to make the impossible suddenly possible?

I pushed the thought away as I turned under the sheets, pulling Daisy's warm body against mine. She murmured sleepily and nestled closer, her trust in me complete. That trust was sacred, I knew that. And I would never do anything to betray it.

But deep in my heart, in the dark corners of my mind where secret desires lived, the fantasy remained.

Waiting, hoping, wondering what if.

Modern Husbandry: A Curious Discovery

Home and Heart

A Blog By @DemureMillieGrace

Hello, lovely readers,

I was browsing the internet today when I stumbled upon something absolutely fascinating—a whole world of blogs about "modern husbands" and "modern marriages." The more I read, the more intrigued I became. These men write about doing housework, supporting their wives' careers, sharing domestic responsibilities... and I wonder what other boundaries they are exploring?

It's such a contrast to everything I believe about traditional marriage roles, yet I found myself reading post after post. How far would these modern husbands really go to support their wives? What exactly constitutes a "modern marriage" these days?

I definitely need to research this further. Perhaps this could be the start of a whole new movement that I was unaware of, until now. Sometimes the internet reveals the most unexpected corners of the world! If I discover more and think it might be of interest to you, my wonderful readers, I'll let you know!

Yours in curiosity and intrigue,

Millie Grace

Chapter two

Chapter 2: Reflections

The next morning, I sat staring at my dual monitors in the room I'd claimed as my studio. It wasn't much, barely more than a converted conservatory really, but it had great natural light and was quiet enough for me to lose myself in my work. My Mac setup dominated the small space alongside the physical art supplies I hadn't used yet since moving in.

"Jordan?" Daisy's voice drifted down from upstairs. "Where are you?"

"Down in the studio!" I called back, not taking my eyes off the screen where I was putting finishing touches on an elven warrior's armour. The commission was for a gaming software company, character concepts for their upcoming fantasy RPG. "I got up early to finish this project. Deadline's noon today."

I could hear the shower running upstairs for a moment, then it stopped. She must have just gotten out.

"I'll make your coffee and breakfast," I added, saving my progress and stretching. The metallic textures were nearly perfect, but I'd been hunched over the Wacom tablet for over an hour. I needed this gig. If it worked out, it could lead to more work. Maybe even a contract.

I headed into the kitchen and started the familiar morning routine: coffee in the machine, bread in the toaster, checking my phone for any emails from the client. The kitchen felt peaceful in the early light, our new home still holding that fresh start feeling.

"You're an angel," I heard Daisy say as she came down the stairs, "I need to iron this shirt. It got a bit creased in the wardrobe."

I was facing the counter, waiting for the coffee to brew, while she continued chatting about her early meeting, something about a mediation case.

"The partners want me there by eight, which means leaving here by — oh, you've already got everything ready."

I turned to face her, smile ready, and the words died in my throat.

She was standing there in nothing but a pair of pale pink panties, completely relaxed and unselfconscious. Her damp blonde hair caught the early morning light streaming through the large front windows, the aforementioned white shirt and a pink bra in one hand.

She caught my expression and giggled. “What? It’s our house, Jordan. I can wander around however I like. Besides, I just need to quickly iron this.”

“The curtains,” I managed, gesturing toward the large front windows. “And the blinds. They’re open.”

Daisy glanced over as she set up the ironing board, then shrugged, her brown eyes unconcerned. “No one’s going to be looking this early. It’s barely seven.”

I relaxed a little. She was probably right. Who would be up and looking into our windows at this hour?

She moved efficiently, ironing the shirt with clumsy strokes before I took over.

“Let me,” I told her, and took over, ironing it smooth while she finished buttering the toast. When I handed her the warm but perfectly ironed garment back, she quickly slipped into her bra and then the freshly pressed blouse. I nodded my approval as she buttoned it up to the top and looked at me with a questioning smile. “You look great,” I told her. “Now go put some trousers on.”

“Okay. I’ll be down in five minutes,” she giggled, a slice of toast in her hand. “Don’t let me forget to grab those case files from my desk.”

I watched her head back upstairs, enjoying the sight of her bare legs and tight ass in her panties, then turned back to prepare my breakfast. Almost immediately, I heard the familiar whir of the hairdryer starting up from our bedroom.

I filled a cup of my own with coffee and placed two slices of freshly buttered toast on a plate, but just as I sat down at the kitchen table, I glanced out the window to check the weather, and something caught my eye.

The sun was still low in the sky, barely risen, but enough to cast golden light across the cul-de-sac, and a flash of light from the upstairs window of the house directly across made me look twice. As I peered through the window from my seat at the table, I saw it again. Two flashes, just a few inches apart. Like two small objects reflecting the light, just for a split second. Then it happened again, slightly to the left of the first time. A double glint that lasted just long enough for me to notice before disappearing.

I stared at the window, waiting to see if it would happen again. Nothing.

It was almost as if... Binoculars? No, surely not. Who would be watching our quiet cul-de-sac at seven in the morning with binoculars?

But the twin flashes had been too distinctive, too deliberate to be just sunlight on the window, and they'd moved, too.

I shook my head and headed back to my studio, the hairdryer still humming upstairs. I was probably being paranoid. Daisy was right, no one would be looking this early.

Twenty minutes later, Daisy was rushing around in full ready-for-work mode, gathering her case files and checking her reflection one last time in the hallway mirror.

"Drive carefully," I said, kissing her goodbye at the front door. "Beware of cyclists and dog walkers."

"Very funny." She laughed, shouldering her briefcase. "I'll be fine, I promise."

I watched her reverse out of the drive, then settled back into my studio to tackle the final details on the elven warrior. The deadline of midday would

be upon me before I knew it, and I needed every hour I could get.

I was deep in adjusting the highlight layers when the doorbell rang around eleven thirty. Through the frosted glass, I could see the familiar silhouette of a tall figure. I opened the door to find Tyler from next door — a mature Black man with greying temples and an easy smile. He and his wife, Morgan, had been the first to welcome us to Far Bridge Rise when we moved in, bringing over some incredible lemon drizzle cake that Morgan had baked.

“Jordan, hey!” Tyler said, extending his hand. “How are you settling in?”

“Really well, thanks. Morgan’s cakes certainly helped with the transition,” I said with a grin. “How’s she doing?”

“She’s great, thanks for asking. Actually, that’s partly why I’m here. I heard through the grapevine that you and Daisy met a couple more of the neighbours yesterday. That accident with Corinne’s dog?”

I nodded. “Yeah, a bit of excitement for a Tuesday afternoon. Everyone was okay, thankfully.”

“That’s good to hear. Bluebell’s a lovely dog, but she’s got a mind of her own.” Tyler shifted on the doorstep. “So, I thought it might be pertinent to invite you and Daisy to our neighbourhood meeting tonight. Seven o’clock at Kelly’s house, number twenty-three.”

I looked puzzled. “Kelly?”

“You haven’t met her yet. Lives up toward the end of the rise. We all take turns hosting the meetings. Keeps it informal, you know? Kelly volunteered for this month.”

“What kind of meeting?”

“We meet once a month, sometimes more if there’s something specific to discuss. Nothing too formal, just a chance for everyone to stay connected, talk about any issues, that sort of thing.” Tyler seemed to sense my

hesitation. “Look, I know it might seem a bit much when you’re still settling in, but honestly, it’s a good crowd. And we have snacks.”

“Snacks, you say?” I couldn’t help but smile. “What kind of issues do you usually discuss?”

“Oh, the usual suburban stuff. Parking, maintenance of the common areas, and coordinating street parties. Lately, we’ve had some trouble with kids coming in from the woods and the country park. You know, those pathways that lead into the back of the rise? Sometimes we get teenagers hanging around late at night, leaving a mess, that sort of thing.”

I thought about the double glint I’d seen earlier, the uneasy feeling it’d given me for a moment. Maybe it wouldn’t hurt to know more about what went on in our quiet cul-de-sac.

“You know what? That sounds good. What time did you say?”

“Seven o’clock. Number twenty-three. The house with the blue front door and the climbing roses. You can’t miss it.”

“We’ll be there. Thanks for thinking of us, Tyler.”

“Great! Morgan will be pleased. She’s been wanting to properly introduce you both to everyone.” He started to head back down the path, then turned. “Oh, and Jordan? Don’t worry about it being formal or anything. We’re all pretty laid-back. Just neighbours helping neighbours, you know?”

As I watched him walk back to his own house, I found myself curious about what the evening would bring. It would be good to put faces to the houses around us, and maybe I’d even meet whoever lived in that house across the rise.

By eleven-fifty, I was putting the finishing touches on the elven warrior’s gauntlets. The metallic sheen caught the digital light perfectly, and I felt that familiar satisfaction of a piece coming together exactly as I’d envisioned it. I saved the final version, exported it at the requested resolution, and crafted a professional email to the client.

Hi Sarah,

Please find attached the completed character concepts for the elven warrior as discussed. I've included both the full-colour version and the line art variant you requested. The armour detailing and magical runes should translate well to the game.

Looking forward to your feedback and hopefully discussing the remaining characters in the series.

Best regards, Jordan

I hit send at 11:58 AM — with two minutes to spare.

With the pressure of the deadline lifted, I found myself wandering around my little studio, looking at the physical art supplies I rarely touched anymore. My easel stood in the corner, a half-finished landscape from months ago still clipped to it. Tubes of oil paint sat neatly arranged on the old wooden palette, and my collection of brushes, for everything from fine detail work to broad strokes, waited patiently in their glass jar.

There was something appealing about the idea of starting something new, something just for me rather than a client. Maybe a portrait, or another attempt at that tricky light-and-shadow study I'd been putting off. My fingers itched to feel the texture of real paint again, to work with something that couldn't be undone with Ctrl+Z.

The rest of the day went incident-free as I did the chores around the house, and as I was finishing the vacuuming, I heard Daisy's car door slam shut outside. I met her at the front door as she juggled her briefcase and a small stack of files. She looked pleased with herself, that particular glow she got when work had gone well.

"Good day?" I asked, taking the files from her and giving her a proper hello kiss.

"Really good, actually. The meeting was nothing to worry about, then I sat in on the mediation case, which went better than expected. Both parties

were more reasonable than their lawyers suggested they'd be." She kicked off her heels with obvious relief. "And you'll be proud to know I successfully avoided all cyclists and dog walkers on the drive home."

I laughed. "I knew you had it in you. Coffee?"

"Please. Tell me you finished the commission on time?"

"Sent it off with two minutes to spare," I said, heading to the kitchen. "And speaking of timing, Tyler from next door came by earlier. We've been invited to a neighbourhood meeting tonight."

Daisy paused in the middle of loosening her tie. "A neighbourhood meeting?"

"Seven o'clock at number twenty-three, someone called Kelly is hosting. Tyler says they meet monthly, sometimes more often if there are issues to discuss. Apparently, there's been some trouble with kids coming in from the country park pathways."

Her face lit up with interest. "That sounds good! I'd love to meet more of the neighbours properly. We've only really chatted briefly with Tyler and a couple of others."

"I thought you might be interested. Tyler mentioned snacks."

"Well, now you've completely sold me." She grinned. "What should we bring? Wine? Flowers? I don't want to show up empty-handed."

"Flowers?" I laughed at the bizarre suggestion. "Tyler made it sound pretty informal, but maybe a bottle of wine wouldn't go amiss."

Daisy nodded, already mentally planning. "Perfect. It'll be nice to put faces to all the houses. And maybe we'll finally meet whoever lives in that big house directly across from us — the one with the lovely garden."

I thought again about the double glint I'd seen that morning from that very house, wondering if tonight would solve the mystery of whether someone

had been watching earlier, perhaps for neighbourhood watch purposes. But as early as seven in the morning? “Yeah,” I agreed. “It’ll be interesting.”

Later, we found ourselves in our bedroom getting ready for the meeting. Daisy was still in her work clothes and was rifling through her wardrobe, trying to decide what struck the right balance between friendly neighbour and professional woman.

“What do you think?” she asked, holding up a light blue blouse against herself. “Too formal?”

“Perfect,” I said, sitting on the edge of the bed and watching her. She unbuttoned her shirt and tossed it aside, completely unselfconscious, and I found my eyes automatically drifting toward the window that faced the house across Far Bridge Rise. Nothing. No movement, no suspicious glints of light this time. Just ordinary windows reflecting the early evening sun.

Stop being paranoid, I told myself firmly. No one was watching this morning. No one is watching now.

“You’re quiet,” Daisy observed, buttoning up the blue blouse. “Having second thoughts about the meeting?”

“No, not at all.” I stood up and straightened my own shirt. “Actually, I’m quite looking forward to it.”

“Me too.” She smiled, checking her reflection in the mirror. “I love meeting new people, and it sounds like we’ve got a good community here.”

A half hour later, we were walking down Far Bridge Rise toward the local shop. The evening was warm, and several neighbours were out in their gardens or washing cars. A few waved as we passed, and I found myself trying to match faces to the houses, as Daisy had described it. I made a note of the house number opposite ours, seventeen. That was the one I’d be most interested in meeting the occupants of.

The convenience store was small but well-stocked, with a decent wine selection for its size. We stood in front of the bottles, debating our choice.

“What about this Shiraz?” I suggested, picking up a bottle with an elegant label. The price was reasonable and the vintage looked respectable. “Tyler mentioned they’re a laid-back crowd, so nothing too fancy, but we don’t want to look cheap either.”

“Perfect,” Daisy agreed. “Something they can enjoy tonight or save for later.”

As we walked back toward Kelly’s house, I noticed Daisy’s excitement building. She was practically bouncing on her toes, probably already planning conversation topics and rehearsing conversations in her head.

“Look, there’s number twenty-three,” she said, pointing ahead to a house with a blue front door and climbing roses, exactly as Tyler had described. The front windows glowed warmly, and I could see figures moving around inside.

“Ready?” I asked as we approached the front path.

“Absolutely.” She squeezed my arm. “Though I’m a bit nervous about remembering everyone’s names.”

“We’ll figure it out,” I assured her, though I was wondering the same thing privately. How many neighbours would be there? And more importantly, would I finally meet whoever lived in number seventeen, where I’d seen the glint of binocular lenses?

We knocked on the door, and almost instantly, Kelly answered the door with a warm smile, an attractive woman in her late forties with auburn hair and laughter lines that suggested she smiled often. “You must be Jordan and Daisy! I’m Kelly. Come in, come in!”

The living room buzzed with conversation, and I was surprised by the number of people already there. Kelly accepted our bottle of wine with obvious pleasure, and we were quickly swept into introductions.

“You remember Corinne from yesterday,” Tyler said, walking over the moment he saw us, and gesturing toward the redhead by the window. She

was chatting animatedly with a stocky man with kind eyes. “And that’s her husband, Paul. They live at number one.”

Corinne saw us and waved with genuine warmth. Then her attention turned to someone over my shoulder. “How’s your elbow healing, Kendall?” I turned to see the familiar dark-haired young woman perched on the arm of a sofa.

“Much better, thanks to Jordan here,” Kendall replied with a grin. Next to her was an older white couple, and she nudged the man. “Dad, Mum, these are the neighbours I told you about, Jordan and Daisy. They patched me up yesterday.” Both her parents had fair skin that contrasted with Kendall’s olive complexion, making it clear she’d inherited her darker features from elsewhere in the family tree.

“Linda and Frank Petrosky,” the woman introduced herself, extending a firm handshake. “Number fourteen. We can’t thank you enough for taking care of our girl.”

“It was nothing,” I protested, but Frank clapped me on the shoulder appreciatively.

Standing nearby was a young man who shared Kendall’s striking looks, the same olive skin and dark eyes. “This is my son Michael,” Linda added proudly. “Kendall’s brother.”

Across the room, a handsome man in his early thirties was standing with a stunning blonde woman. “And that’s Russell and his wife Charlotte from number eleven,” Frank informed us. “Russell’s the friend Alex was visiting when yesterday’s accident happened.”

Russell looked up and came over when he saw us looking. “Pleasure to meet you properly,” he said, shaking my hand. “Alex felt terrible about it all. I’ve already apologised again to Kendall.”

Near the kitchen door, an absolutely gorgeous couple caught my eye, a woman with long dark hair and striking features talking intimately with a tall, athletic man who looked like he could have stepped out of a fashion

magazine. “That’s Angelica and Marco from number nine,” Russell said, following my gaze, continuing the chain of introductions. “They moved in about six months ago. He’s something in finance, she works in fashion.”

A petite woman with silver hair approached us, carrying a plate of what appeared to be homemade cookies. “I’m Margaret, number four. Welcome to Far Bridge Rise!” Her Scottish accent was warm and motherly. “And this is my husband, Robert.” She gestured to a distinguished man with a grey beard who was staring intently at his phone.

Near the fireplace, a couple in their thirties were discussing school catchment areas with animated gestures. “That’s James and Emma from number eighteen,” Margaret continued quietly. “They’ve got two young kids and are very involved with local schools.”

A tall, lean man with thinning hair stood alone by the bookshelf, nursing what looked like a whisky. “And Simon from number seven,” Margaret added, lowering her voice even further. “Bit of a loner, but harmless. Works in IT.”

In the corner, an elderly couple sat holding hands, the woman using a walking stick. “Eleanor and Geoffrey from number twenty-one. Sweetest couple you’ll ever meet. Been married sixty years.”

“And you know Morgan,” Tyler added, joining us just as his wife appeared from the kitchen carrying a tray of glasses, some with wine, some with soft drinks. She was dark-skinned and glamorous. Tall, slim and at least a decade younger than her husband.

“Jordan! Daisy! So lovely to see you again,” Morgan beamed. “How are you settling in?”

As we chatted and mingled, I found myself scanning the room, trying to remember which house everyone lived in. It was a fascinating cross-section of the cul-de-sac, from young families to retirees, all gathered in Kelly’s comfortable living room. As Daisy had feared, there was no way I was going to remember everyone’s name. Not yet, at least.

As the evening progressed, I found myself naturally gravitating toward Tyler and Morgan while Daisy was drawn into an animated conversation with Kelly about the stunning climbing roses that adorned the front of the house.

“Those flowers are absolutely gorgeous,” I heard Daisy say, gesturing toward the window. “What variety are they? I’m thinking of planting something similar.”

“Those are David Austin roses,” Kelly replied warmly, refilling Daisy’s wine glass. “Pink Prosperity, I think. They’ve been there since before I moved in, but they’re divine, aren’t they?”

While they chatted about gardening, I seized the opportunity to satisfy my curiosity. “Morgan,” I said quietly, moving closer to her as Tyler was pulled into a discussion about parking permits with James and Emma. “Clearly, not everyone from the cul-de-sac is involved in these meetings. I was wondering about the house directly across from ours, number seventeen. Do you know who lives there?”

Morgan’s eyes lit up with interest, and she stepped closer to me, close enough that I could smell her perfume, something floral and expensive. “Yes. Sadly, some in the neighbourhood aren’t interested in being neighbourly,” she said, then smiled playfully, her fingers brushing my arm as she spoke. “But I’m glad you’ve joined us.”

“I just wanted to tell them how lovely their garden is,” I replied, aware of how her touch lingered a moment longer than necessary. “As they live directly across from us, it’s a nice sight to walk out to every morning. I think I saw them through the window this morning, but — “

“Oh, darling,” Morgan laughed, a sound like wind chimes. “No. That house has been empty for over a month now. The previous owners, the Hendersons, moved to Spain quite suddenly. Something about early retirement and the Mediterranean.”

I frowned. “Empty? Are you sure? Because I could have sworn I saw someone — “

“Jordan,” Morgan interrupted, placing her hand on my forearm again and giving it a gentle squeeze. “Trust me on this one. The house is definitely vacant. Has been since early July. Kelly here has been tending to the garden to stop it from getting overgrown.”

Her confidence was absolute, but something about her dismissive tone left me unsettled. “I suppose it could have been shadows, or maybe a reflection...”

“Exactly,” she said, her smile widening. “Reflections.” She moved even closer, ostensibly to speak more quietly, but I was acutely aware of how her hip brushed against mine.

Before she could respond further, Tyler appeared at Morgan’s elbow. “What are you two conspiring about over here?”

“Just neighbourhood gossip,” Morgan replied smoothly, finally stepping back but not before giving my arm one final pat. “Jordan was asking about the empty house across from theirs.”

“Ah, seventeen,” Tyler nodded. “Shame about the Hendersons moving so suddenly. Nice couple. Left the place in good condition, though, and Kelly’s been tending to the lawn and shrubs — the landlord should find new tenants soon enough. Houses on Far Bridge Rise don’t stay empty for long. It’s a desirable neighbourhood, despite those annoying kids.”

I nodded absently, but Morgan’s certainty about the house being empty only deepened my unease. I had seen something that morning, movement, a double flash of light that looked suspiciously like binoculars catching the sun. But if the house was truly vacant, what had I witnessed?

As the evening wound down and we said our goodbyes, I couldn’t shake the feeling that something wasn’t quite right. Either my eyes had played tricks on me, or someone was spending time in a house that was supposed to be empty.

The question was: if someone was there, why the secrecy? And more unsettling still — what exactly were they watching for?

The mystery of number seventeen would have to wait for another day, but as we walked home through the quiet cul-de-sac, I couldn't help but glance toward its darkened windows, wondering what secrets it might be hiding.

Behind the Mask: The Art of Keeping Secrets

Home and Heart

A blog by @DemureMillieGrace

Sometimes I wonder if we all wear masks, even in our most intimate relationships. Today I found myself thinking about how little we truly know about the people closest to us — our neighbours, our friends, even our spouses. Everyone has their private thoughts, their hidden desires, their secret curiosities.

Take my own marriage, for instance. Mr Heart thinks I don't notice his little habits, his quiet observations, even the way he glances at other women when he thinks I'm not looking. But I see everything. And truthfully? It doesn't bother me the way it probably should. There's something almost... liberating about acknowledging that we all have parts of ourselves we keep hidden.

The real question isn't whether people have secrets; of course, they do. The question is whether those secrets bring us closer to who we really are, or further away from the people we love.

Sometimes the most traditional marriages hide the most unconventional truths.

Yours with secrets and masks,

Millie Grace

Chapter three

Chapter 3: What Lay Beneath

The evening air still held the warmth of the day as we walked slowly back along Far Bridge Rise. Daisy had looped her arm through mine, and was leaning into me, her weight against my shoulder. The wine from Kelly's had left her in that perfect state between tipsy and drunk — loose-limbed and content, with a dreamy smile playing at the corners of her mouth.

"That was more fun than I thought it would be," she said, her words carrying just the faintest hint of a slur. "I feel like we've found a nice place, you know? After all those years in that awful flat with the paper-thin walls and neighbours who never even said hello."

She paused to admire the front garden of the house next to ours — not Tyler and Morgan's — swaying slightly as she leaned forward to smell the late summer roses. Her blonde hair caught the streetlight, creating a soft halo around her face, and I found myself struck by how beautiful she looked in this moment, her cheeks flushed with wine and happiness, her guard completely down.

"Kelly's house is gorgeous," she continued as we resumed walking. "Did you see that kitchen? Those granite countertops must have cost a fortune. And she's so lovely, offering to let me take some cuttings of those climbing roses. I've always wanted to try my hand at proper gardening."

"What did you think of Tyler and Morgan?" I asked, curious about her impressions.

Daisy's face lit up. "Oh, they're cool! Tyler seems so... I don't know, dependable? Like the kind of person you'd want on your side in a crisis. And Morgan is absolutely gorgeous, isn't she? That bone structure, those cheekbones... She could be a model."

As if summoned by our conversation, my phone buzzed with a text message. I pulled it out, seeing Tyler's name on the screen.

"Speak of the devil," I said, showing Daisy the screen before reading it aloud. "Everyone really liked you both tonight. Because we had so much fun, we completely forgot to ask if you want to join the neighbourhood watch officially. Would you like to?"

Daisy's eyes widened with excitement. "Really? That's wonderful! We've only been here a week and they're already including us."

I found myself typing back a question before I could stop myself: What exactly does the watch entail?

Tyler's response came almost immediately: I'll go over all the details tomorrow. It's just a way of keeping the cul-de-sac safe. Nothing too demanding.

Something about the vagueness unsettled me, though I couldn't put my finger on why. The glint of light on lenses that I'd seen this morning... had that been something to do with the watch? But if so, why was Morgan so weird about it?

"This is so exciting," Daisy continued, oblivious to my growing unease. "We'll really be proper neighbours then. Part of the community."

I remembered Morgan's lingering touches earlier, how she'd been slightly.... flirty, when we spoke. "Well, I'm glad you like Tyler and Morgan. As you say, it's good to have friendly neighbours for once.."

"Friendly and glamorous. I felt a bit underdressed next to her, to be honest." Daisy giggled, the sound light and musical. "In fact, is everyone on Far Bridge Rise so well-dressed? Even the men. That Russell is ridiculously handsome, like something out of a magazine. Poor Charlotte, having to live alongside that kind of perfection."

"You're used to it," I teased. "Living with me, I mean."

"I'm married, not blind," she replied with a grin. "Anyway, don't worry, you're much more my type. Russell's too... polished. Too aware of how good-looking he is."

We'd reached our front door, and I fumbled with the keys while Daisy continued her assessment of our new neighbours.

"The older couples seem sweet too," she mused. "Margaret and Robert looked like they've been together forever. Did you see how he kept making sure she had everything she needed? And Eleanor and Geoffrey, holding hands like teenagers. That's what I want us to be like in our later years."

"What about the younger ones? Kendall and her family?"

"Oh, the Petroskys," Daisy nodded enthusiastically. "They seem like a lovely family. Though I couldn't help thinking..." She paused, tilting her head thoughtfully. "Actually, no. It doesn't matter."

"What?" I looked at her quizzically but she shook her head, then giggled at me, still struggling with the door. I finally got it open, and we stumbled inside, both of us still laughing at our slightly unsteady states. The house felt cool and welcoming after the warm evening air.

"I'm starving," Daisy announced, heading straight for the kitchen. "All that wine... I need something to soak it up."

I watched as she rummaged through the fridge, her movements still loose and carefree from the drink. She pulled out some cheese and crackers, along with a few grapes, assembling a simple but appealing late-night snack on a plate for us both. I poured us a drink of juice and handed her one of the glasses.

"Give me five minutes to get comfortable," she said, disappearing upstairs with her glass in hand.

When she returned, I nearly dropped my drink. She'd changed into a pair of tiny sleep shorts that hugged her curves perfectly, paired with a fitted grey T-shirt that was just translucent enough to hint at what lay beneath. Her legs looked impossibly long, and the shorts rode low on her hips, showing a tantalising strip of pale skin at her waist.

"Better?" I asked as she settled onto the sofa beside me, tucking her legs beneath her. The movement caused the shorts to ride up slightly, and I found myself stealing glances at the smooth expanse of her thighs.

"Much," she managed as I tried to focus on the cheese and crackers rather than how the soft cotton of her shirt outlined the shape of her breasts.

She picked at a grape thoughtfully, then sighed. "I should really be doing some work tonight. I've got that essay due next week for Dr Patterson's class."

"What's the topic again?" I asked, though I was more interested in watching her tits wobble slightly as she shifted on the sofa.

"Extra-marital relationships," she said, settling back against the cushions. "The psychology behind infidelity, open relationships, why people cheat, essentially. Then also post-divorce relationships. Returning to old lovers. It's all very interesting." She took a sip of juice, considering. "Meeting all those couples tonight actually gave me some interesting material to think about."

I raised an eyebrow. "Oh?"

"Well, think about it," she said, warming to the subject in that way she did when academic ideas excited her. "How many of them do you think are exactly as perfect as they appeared tonight? Which ones are hiding secrets, or have had affairs, or are maybe even having affairs right now?"

I raised my eyebrow even higher. "That's a bit cynical, isn't it?"

Daisy laughed, a sound that was both innocent and knowing. "It's not cynical. It's realistic. Statistics say that at least thirty percent of married couples will deal with infidelity at some point. So statistically, several of the people we met tonight have either cheated or been cheated on."

I found myself picturing the faces from the evening, Tyler's easy manner, Morgan's flirtatiousness, Russell's movie-star looks, Charlotte's stunning beauty, Kendall's innocence. "Even the older couples?"

"Especially the older couples," Daisy said with a mischievous grin. "They've had more time to get into trouble. Though honestly, I think the sweet ones like Eleanor and Geoffrey are probably the least likely. It's the ones who seem too perfect that make me suspicious."

Something about her words, combined with the earlier drink and the sight of her curled up beside me in those tiny shorts, was having a definite effect on me. "Such as?"

"Tyler and Morgan, for instance," she mused. "They're almost too charming, too put-together. And did you notice how Morgan was with you? Very... attentive, shall we say?"

Daisy had noticed that? Heat crept up my neck. "Was she?"

"Oh, please," Daisy laughed. "She was practically purring every time she spoke to you. Not that I blame her. You're quite attractive when you try. Plus, tales of your heroism have probably spread."

"Did anyone flirt with you?" I asked, trying to deflect, keeping my voice casual despite the way my pulse had quickened.

Daisy smiled, that smile of hers that made her look both innocent and knowing. "A few of the men definitely checked me out," she said matter-of-factly. "Russell was quite charming when we were talking. He made lots of eye contact, and wasn't scared to stand a bit closer than necessary. I think Tyler likes me, too. He's cute, for an older guy. I take it as a compliment, and so should you."

The confession hung in the air between us, and I felt a familiar heat building in my chest, but not the kind I was supposed to feel. Instead of protective anger, I was experiencing something else entirely, something I knew I couldn't let Daisy see. I forced myself to frown, to play the role I knew she expected. "I don't like the sound of that."

"Oh, Jordan," she laughed, setting down her juice and shifting closer to me on the sofa. "You're so sweet when you get all protective. It was just harmless flirting, the kind married people do at parties. Nothing serious."

I should have been relieved by her dismissal, but instead I found myself wanting to know more. As it always did, the thought of Daisy even flirting with someone else turned me on. I couldn't ask her anything further without revealing the effect her words were having on me.

"Still," I said, reaching out to touch her bare knee, "I don't like other men looking at my woman like that."

It was the response she wanted to hear. I could see it in the way her eyes lit up with pleasure. She loved it when I got possessive, when I acted like the jealous husband defending his territory. She had no idea that underneath my performance, I was imagining the opposite scenes in vivid detail, wondering what it would be like if she'd encouraged the attention instead of brushing it off.

"Your woman?" she teased, moving even closer until she was practically in my lap. "How very caveman of you, Mr Hoyland."

"Damn right," I said, sliding my hand up her thigh, feeling the smooth warmth of her skin beneath my palm. "Mine."

She giggled at my mock-serious tone, but I could see the effect my touch was having on her. Her cheeks were flushed, whether from the wine or arousal, I couldn't tell, and her breathing had become slightly shallower.

"Prove it," she whispered, her lips brushing against my ear.

I didn't need to be asked twice. I pulled her fully into my lap, my hands tangling in her hair as I kissed her with all the pent-up desire her confessions had stirred in me. She melted against me, soft and pliant, her own hands finding the buttons of my shirt.

"Upstairs," she murmured against my mouth between kisses. "Take me upstairs and show me exactly how much you missed me while I was charming all those other men."

The words sent another surge of heat through me, and I stood up, pulling her with me. As we headed toward the staircase, I caught a glimpse of our

reflection in the dark front windows, Daisy in her tiny shorts and thin T-shirt, me with my shirt half-unbuttoned, both of us breathing heavily with desire.

For just a moment, I wondered if anyone was watching from across the street, if someone might be getting their own private show. The thought should have made me want to close the curtains. Instead, it made me want her even more.

We barely made it to the bedroom before Daisy was pulling at my shirt, her fingers fumbling with the remaining buttons in her wine-fueled haste. The moonlight streaming through our uncurtained bedroom windows cast everything in silver and shadow, and I realised with a thrill that anyone looking up from the street would have a perfect view of us if we turned the light on. So I left it switched off and then to be sure, I reached out and dragged the curtain across with an outstretched hand.

"You're so beautiful," I murmured against her neck, my hands finding the hem of her T-shirt and slowly lifting it over her head. She wasn't wearing a bra, and her breasts were perfect in the pale light, full and rounded with pale pink nipples that hardened under my gaze. She arched against me as my hands cupped the warm weight of her tits, feeling their softness fill my palms. Her skin was like silk, and I could smell the faint scent of her perfume on her collarbone as I kissed along it.

"Jordan," she breathed as I traced a path down her chest with my lips, between her breasts, tasting the faint saltiness of her skin. "I need you."

My hands moved to the waistband of her tiny shorts, sliding them down her long legs to reveal she wore nothing underneath. She was already glistening with a light sheen of sweat all over her body. Her pussy, with its fine tuft of light hair, was already visibly wet. The sight made my own arousal strain almost painfully against my shorts.

When I finally freed myself from my boxers, my erection stood hard, the head bulging with anticipation, a driplet of pre-cum on the tip. Daisy's eyes darkened as she took in the sight of me, her hand reaching out to stroke my length with feather-light touches that made me groan.

Tell me, I wanted to whisper as I positioned myself between her thighs, my voice rougher than I intended. Tell me what you were thinking when Russell was flirting with you.

But I didn't say it. I couldn't. She looked up at me with heavy-lidded eyes, her lips parted and breathing shallow. "Fuck me," she murmured softly. "Fuck me, Jordan."

I pressed myself against her entrance, feeling her warmth and wetness welcome me as I slowly pushed forward. She was tight and silky, her body yielding to mine as I buried myself inside her.

"Did you like it?" I asked, beginning to move with slow, deep strokes that made her gasp.

"Did I like what?" she asked breathlessly, her hands gripping my shoulders as I set a rhythm that had us both climbing toward ecstasy. "God, yes. That's it. Do it."

I cursed because I hadn't meant to ask that question out loud — I'd almost asked if she'd liked Russell flirting with her. But she didn't question me further. The scent of our lovemaking filled the air, sweat and her wetness combined, while the sound of our bodies colliding echoed from the walls. I watched her face as I moved within her, seeing the way her eyes fluttered closed and her lips parted with each thrust.

Her inner walls clenched around me, hot and wet, as I angled to hit that spot that made her cry out. The visual of my shaft disappearing into her body, glistening with her arousal each time I withdrew, was almost enough to send me over the edge.

"Please," she gasped, her back arching off the bed as I increased the pace. "Jordan, please. Do it. Do it hard." Her hand snaked down between us, frantically rubbing her clit, pushing herself to the edge.

When she finally orgasmed beneath me, her body convulsing around my length as she called out my name, the sight and feel of her climax triggered

my own. I buried myself fully inside her as I came, my release pulsing hot and urgent while she milked every drop from me, then collapsed beside her.

Instead of the expected drowsiness, Daisy stretched languidly beside me, a satisfied smile playing on her lips. I closed my eyes, feeling sleep tugging at me already. "You know what I love about you, Jordan?" she said, tracing circles on my chest with her fingertip. "You always fall asleep right after sex like some contented old man. Meanwhile, I'm completely energised."

I chuckled, though she wasn't wrong. The post-orgasmic haze was already making my eyelids heavy, there was no point in denying it. "Sorry. It's a biological imperative."

"Whatever that means." She laughed, sitting up and stretching her arms above her head. The movement caused her hair to tumble around her shoulders, and even in my drowsy state, I couldn't help but admire the elegant line of her neck. "I'm actually getting a bit peckish again. Plus, we left everything downstairs in a bit of a mess. Did we even remember to lock the front door?"

I blinked, trying to focus. "I... think so?"

"Hmm." She slipped out of bed with surprising grace to say she'd just been well-fucked, completely unselfconscious about her nudity as she looked around for her discarded T-shirt, pulling it back over her head. "I'm going to tidy up a bit. You look tired. Have an early night, if you like."

She was right. The combination of wine, exertion, and the warm bedroom was making me feel heavy-limbed and drowsy. I watched her disappear through the doorway, listening to her light footsteps on the stairs.

After a few minutes of lying there, I realised she was right about it being an early night, not even eleven yet. I forced myself up and padded to the bathroom, splashing cold water on my face to shake off the post-sex lethargy. My reflection looked back at me, hair dishevelled and face still slightly flushed.

I could hear Daisy moving around downstairs, the soft chime of glasses clinking in the sink, the gentle sound of her humming to herself. Deciding to join her and help finish cleaning up before we actually went to bed, I went back to the bedroom to find some clothes.

I'd just pulled on a pair of grey sweatpants when movement outside caught my eye. Through the gap in our bedroom curtains, which I'd hastily tried to draw with one hand, I could see a figure with a dog. Paul, Corinne's husband, was out for a late evening walk with Bluebell.

But he wasn't walking.

He was standing completely still at the bottom of our front garden, the dog's leash slack in his hand while the Weimeraner sniffed around the base of our hedge. Paul himself was staring directly at our house, his face tilted toward the warm glow of our downstairs windows.

My stomach dropped. Daisy was down there in nothing but her T-shirt, tidying up, probably unaware that she had an audience. Through the uncurtained windows, anyone on the street would have a perfect view of her moving around our living room and kitchen.

And Paul wasn't just glancing casually. He was watching intently, his body language focused and deliberate. As I stood frozen at my bedroom window, I could see his head tracking movement inside our house, following Daisy as she moved from room to room.

The rational part of my mind knew I should do something. Call out to warn Daisy. Go downstairs and close the curtains. Knock on the window to let Paul know he'd been spotted.

But I found myself paralysed, caught between outrage and something else, that curiosity and arousal that I'd never dare to talk to Daisy about.

Paul continued to watch, and I continued to watch Paul, and somewhere downstairs, Daisy continued her innocent domestic routine, completely unaware that she had become the star of an impromptu peep show on Far Bridge Rise, possibly not for the first time.

I forced myself to move, padding quietly down the stairs in my sweatpants. As I reached the bottom of the stairs, I could see into the living room where Daisy was bent over, reaching for the juice glasses and small plates we'd abandoned earlier.

The sight stopped me cold.

She was completely bent at the waist, the T-shirt riding up high on her thighs as she stretched to collect the scattered remnants of our impromptu snack. From this angle, from the street's angle, anyone looking through our front windows would have an unobstructed view of her bare bottom and her freshly-fucked pussy, likely still leaking my cum. The thin cotton of the shirt barely covered her breasts, and when she straightened up, I could see her nipples still standing stiff against the fabric, clearly visible through the thin material.

"There you are," she said with a warm smile when she spotted me, completely oblivious to what she'd just inadvertently displayed. "I thought you'd fallen asleep. Are you okay? You look like you've seen a ghost."

I glanced quickly toward the front windows, but the street appeared empty now. No sign of Paul or Bluebell anywhere.

"I'm fine," I managed, though my voice sounded strange even to my own ears. "Just... tired, I suppose."

She tilted her head, studying my face with the perceptive look she got when she sensed something was off. "Are you sure? You seem—"

"Daisy," I interrupted, moving quickly to the windows and yanking the curtains closed with perhaps more force than necessary. "You can't walk around like that with the curtains open. Anyone could see you."

She blinked in surprise at my sudden urgency, then looked down at herself as if just remembering what she was wearing. "Oh. You're right, of course. I'm still a bit tipsy, I think, not thinking clearly."

"I guess," I nodded. "Just be careful in future."

She moved to the other windows around the room, peering out before pulling the curtains shut. "No one's around, though. No harm done, right?"

But there had been someone around. Paul had been standing at the bottom of our garden, watching our house with focused attention. He'd seen her moving through the rooms, and if he'd still been there when she bent over...

How much had he seen exactly? The question lodged itself in my mind like a splinter.

"Jordan?" Daisy's voice pulled me back to the present. "You're acting a bit strange. What's gotten into you?"

I should tell her. I should explain that Paul had been watching, that she needed to be more private. But something held me back, a combination of not wanting to embarrass her and something else, a sense of guilt that I'd not rushed down sooner.

"Nothing," I said finally. "It's just... You know they do a neighbourhood watch. Someone could be doing just that... Watching."

"I didn't think about that," she nodded thoughtfully, then seemed to shrug it off as if she wasn't bothered. "I'll be more aware in future."

As she gathered the last of our dishes, I found myself thinking about the empty house across the street. What if Paul had access to it somehow? What if he'd been watching this morning, too?

The pieces of a disturbing puzzle were assembling in my mind, even if they didn't fit together yet. And even if they did, I wasn't sure I wanted to see the complete picture.

Psychology 320: Human Sexual Behaviour - Essay Draft Notes

Daisy May Hoyland

Topic: Infidelity in Modern Relationships — Statistical Analysis and Psychological Drivers

Key Statistics:

20% of married men vs. 13% of married women admit to extramarital affairs (2025 data)

Peak infidelity age: Men 50-59 (28%), Women 50-59 (17%)

44% of unmarried relationships experience infidelity vs. 18% of married couples

25-50% of divorces primarily caused by affairs

Average woman has first affair 7 years into marriage

37% of affairs start with friends, 30% with coworkers

Children of cheating parents 2x more likely to cheat themselves

Primary Motivations for Infidelity:

Emotional needs unmet (loneliness/boredom) - 30.3% women

Sexual dissatisfaction - 15% cite spouse's lost sex drive

Opportunity + low impulse control

Revenge for partner's infidelity - 8.8%

Seeking novelty/adventure - 14.7%

Digital Era Impact:

25% use dating apps for affairs

40% engage in cybersex

42% of Tinder users already in relationships

Research Question: Do couples in close-knit communities (suburban neighbourhoods) exhibit different infidelity patterns due to social surveillance vs. opportunity factors?

Note: Need to expand this into a full 2,500-word analysis. Focus on psychological drivers vs. sociological constraints. Interview subjects? Neighbourhood case study?

Chapter four

Chapter 4: The Modern Husband

My stomach grumbled as I sorted through the last load of laundry from the tumble dryer. I hadn't eaten yet this morning. Daisy had left an hour ago for a psychology lecture at the university, kissing me goodbye at the front door with that distracted academic focus she got when her mind was already racing ahead to seminars and research papers.

I should have been looking for work. I'd finished the elven warrior commission for the indie gaming studio and was now waiting to hear back from Sarah about the remaining characters in the series. My dual monitors downstairs stood silent, no urgent deadlines demanding my attention. Instead, I found myself moving through our morning routine with unusual deliberation, my thoughts entirely elsewhere.

I carried the warm pile of clothes to the dining table, Daisy's underwear somehow ending up on top of the stack—a delicate pair of pale pink panties and matching bra that I'd seen her wear just days ago. The sight of them sent my mind wandering back to last night's events as I began to fold.

The memory of Paul's silhouette watching our house, of Daisy unknowingly displaying herself in the kitchen window, sent an unexpected thrill through me that I couldn't quite shake. I'd seen voyeurism before in films, read about it in articles, but experiencing it firsthand—witnessing another man's desire for my wife—had awakened something I wasn't entirely prepared to confront.

The rational part of my mind insisted I should be angry. Outraged. A proper husband would have marched straight over to number one and confronted Paul about his inappropriate Peeping Tom behaviour. But that wasn't what had happened. Instead, I'd stood there in the darkness of the bedroom, pulse quickening, watching him watch her. And when Daisy had bent over to load the dishwasher, her thin T-shirt riding up to reveal her naked and freshly-fucked pussy, I'd felt a surge of pride rather than possessiveness.

My phone buzzed on the table, pulling me from my thoughts. On the screen was a text message from Tyler.

Good morning Jordan. Morgan and I wondered if we could pop round this morning to chat about the neighbourhood watch details we mentioned yesterday evening? We have some paperwork for you. Would 11 AM work?

I glanced at the clock. Ten-thirty. Perfect timing, actually. It'd give me something to focus on besides my increasingly complicated feelings about last night's events.

Good morning, Tyler, I replied. 11 AM sounds great. See you then.

I quickly finished folding the clothes, placing the neat stack on the table, then headed to make fresh coffee and finally grab some breakfast. Through the front windows, Far Bridge Rise looked picture-perfect in the morning sunshine. Neat lawns, trimmed hedges, the kind of suburban tranquillity that estate agents loved to photograph for their brochures. Yet beneath that pristine surface, I was beginning to suspect, lay currents I was only just starting to understand.

At precisely eleven o'clock, I spotted Tyler and Morgan walking up our drive. Tyler carried a manila folder thick with papers, while Morgan had a tablet in her hands. They looked official, professional, exactly like coordinators of a legitimate neighbourhood watch scheme should look.

I opened the door before they could knock. "Tyler, Morgan. Come in."

"Jordan, thanks so much for agreeing to this," Tyler said, shaking my hand firmly. Morgan smiled that slightly too-warm smile I remembered from the evening meeting, her dark eyes lingering on mine a fraction longer than necessary.

"Coffee?" I offered, leading them toward the kitchen.

"That would be lovely," Morgan said, her voice carrying that subtle hint of suggestion that made me wonder if she was talking about more than just coffee.

As we settled around the dining table, I watched Tyler's eyes briefly pause on the stack of laundry, his gaze lingering just a moment too long on Daisy's pale pink underwear before he cleared his throat and opened his manila folder. I cursed inwardly, knowing I should have taken the clothes upstairs before they arrived.

"Right then," Tyler said, spreading several documents across the table with professional efficiency. "We thought it would be helpful to give you all the official paperwork for our neighbourhood watch scheme. Get you properly up to speed."

Morgan leaned forward, her tablet glowing as she pulled up what appeared to be a digital contact directory. She was wearing a beige cardigan over a white blouse that was unbuttoned at the top, so that when she bent over, I caught a glimpse of her impressive cleavage. "We like to keep things well-organised," she said, her voice warm and encouraging. "Nothing too demanding, but we've found structure really helps when it comes to community safety."

Tyler handed me a welcome letter printed on official-looking letterhead. "This is from Frank and Linda. They're our main coordinators. You met them yesterday, they live at number fourteen."

"With their son, Michael and Kendall, who you helped the other day. They're a lovely family," Morgan added, though something in her tone suggested something I couldn't quite put a name to. Was it... jealousy? "Frank takes the whole neighbourhood watch thing very seriously. He's ex-military, you know. And Linda's brilliant with the administrative side. She made all these documents."

I scanned the letter while Tyler continued to lay out papers: a crime prevention checklist, meeting schedules, and emergency contact procedures. Everything looked legitimate, professional, exactly what you'd expect from a genuine community watch program.

"Now, this is probably the most useful thing," Tyler said, unfolding a detailed map of Far Bridge Rise. The T-shaped cul-de-sac was clearly marked, with every house number labelled and resident names listed in neat

print. "It'll help you keep track of who lives where, always useful for new residents."

I studied the map with genuine interest. There was our house at number eight, Tyler and Morgan at six, and the mysterious empty house at seventeen directly across from us. Everyone we'd met yesterday was on there, too, though no one else was.

"This is incredibly thorough," I said, impressed despite thinking it was just a touch of overkill.

"We pride ourselves on being well-prepared," Morgan said, leaning closer to point out various features on the map, the two paths that led from the far ends of the cul-de-sac and the local park. Her proximity was impossible to ignore — the subtle scent of her perfume, her breath against my cheek, the way her fingers almost brushed mine as she traced the patrol routes.

"Speaking of which," Tyler said, pulling out another sheet, "We've got a contact list for you. It makes communication so much easier when issues arise." He handed me a printed directory with phone numbers and email addresses for all residents.

"We'll need your and Daisy's details to add to our master list," Morgan said, her tablet ready. "Just mobile numbers and email addresses for now, nothing too invasive."

I rattled off our information while Morgan typed, acutely aware of how the simple act of sharing contact details felt like crossing some invisible threshold. These neighbours who'd been strangers just days ago were rapidly becoming integrated into our daily lives.

"Perfect," Tyler said, gathering some of the papers together. "Oh, I'm afraid I've got to dash. I completely forgot I promised to help Paul with something at number one." He stood, checking his watch. "Morgan, would you mind finishing up the details with Jordan? I know you wanted to discuss the patrol scheduling."

"Of course," Morgan said smoothly, her smile widening slightly as Tyler took a step back. "We've got quite a lot to cover still."

As Tyler passed me the documents to keep while sliding the others back into his folder, I caught him taking another lingering look at the laundry pile, his gaze settling deliberately on Daisy's underwear. This time it wasn't accidental. It was purposeful, almost appreciative. A flush of discomfort mixed with something else I couldn't quite identify spread through my chest.

"Right then, I'll leave you in Morgan's capable hands," Tyler said, finally tearing his eyes away from my wife's bra and panties. "She knows the patrol systems better than anyone."

After Tyler left, the atmosphere in the room shifted subtly. Morgan settled back into the chair, somehow managing to position herself so that her blouse gaped slightly at the neckline again. I tried to focus on the few documents spread across the table, but found my attention drawn to the inner curves of her breasts, revealed by her relaxed positioning.

"Now then," Morgan said, her voice taking on a more intimate tone now that we were alone. "Let me explain how our surveillance system really works." She leaned forward, ostensibly to point at the map, but the movement provided me with an even better view of her cleavage, her breasts pressed together between her arms.

"We've found that the most effective neighbourhood watch operates on multiple levels," she continued, her finger tracing routes on the map while she watched my face for reactions. Her deep brown eyes were pretty. Morgan really was attractive. I'd never really been attracted to darker-skinned women, or women older than me, but here she was. "There's the obvious patrols, of course, but the real security comes from casual observation from inside our homes."

She moved seats, sitting on one closer, her perfume filling the space between us. "For instance, I can see most of the southern sweep of the rise from my bedroom window. Tyler has a perfect view of the country park

path from his office. It's all about positioning ourselves to keep an eye on things."

I nodded, trying to process the information while acutely aware of her proximity. "And you share what you observe?"

"Oh yes," Morgan said, her hand briefly touching my arm. "We have a WhatsApp group for immediate concerns, but sometimes it's better to discuss things in person. For more... detailed conversations."

She pulled out a tablet, scrolling through what appeared to be a patrol rota. "We try to coordinate so that someone's watching most nights, especially when people are away. Video doorbells are incredibly helpful, we share access when necessary for security purposes."

The implications of that statement sent a slight shiver down my spine. "Share access?"

"Just for safety," Morgan said quickly, though her smile suggested more complex motives. "If someone's away and their camera picks up unusual activity, we can all respond more quickly. Very neighbourly, don't you think?"

She reached across me to grab another document, her breast brushing against my arm in a way that felt far from accidental. "Now, outdoor cameras are even more useful. I assume you and Daisy have some security measures in place?"

Before I could answer, my phone rang. Daisy's name appeared on the screen, and I felt both relief and guilt as I answered.

"Hi darling," I said, perhaps a bit too enthusiastically.

"Jordan? You sound... weird. Is everything okay?" Daisy's voice was loud enough through the speaker for Morgan to hear, and I noticed her eyes brighten with interest.

"Fine, fine. Just having a meeting about the neighbourhood watch. Tyler and Morgan came over with all the paperwork."

"Oh, cool! I'm between lectures and thought I'd check in. Are you learning lots about community safety?"

"More than I expected," I said, glancing at Morgan, who was now openly listening to every word. "It's quite comprehensive, actually."

"That's wonderful. I thought Morgan came across as such a lovely woman at the meeting — I enjoyed chatting with her. Is she still there?"

I hesitated, aware of Morgan's intense focus on the conversation. "Yes, she's just explaining some of the watch procedures."

"Oh, perfect! Could you put me on speaker for a moment? I'd love to say hello properly."

My stomach dropped. The last thing I wanted was for Daisy to be on speaker while Morgan sat there in her low-cut blouse, having spent the morning flirting with me over my wife's underwear. "Actually, we're just finishing up the paperwork and—"

"Nonsense," Morgan interjected loudly enough for Daisy to hear. "I'd love to say hello too. Please, put her on speaker."

I hesitated, but before I could object, Morgan reached across, took my phone and pressed the speaker button, then gave it back to me. Her hand lingered on mine for a moment longer than necessary.

"Daisy! How lovely to hear from you," Morgan's voice took on a warm, sisterly tone completely different from her earlier sultry manner.

"Morgan! How nice. I hope Jordan's not being too much trouble. He can be quite useless with administrative things."

"On the contrary," Morgan said, her eyes locked on mine with an expression that made my pulse quicken, "He's been absolutely perfect. Very... attentive to all the details."

"That's my modern husband," Daisy laughed. "Always happy to help."

Morgan's eyebrows raised with obvious interest. "Modern husband?" she asked, her tone genuinely curious. "Forgive me, but I'm not entirely sure what that means."

"Oh, Jordan does most of the domestic work. Cooking, cleaning, laundry, that sort of thing. He fully supports my career, even when it means he has to take a backseat professionally. We're equals in our marriage, but he's definitely the one who keeps our home running smoothly while I'm out earning a living and paying the bills."

"How refreshing," Morgan said, her gaze settling on me with what seemed like newfound appreciation. "That's quite... progressive of you both."

"I contribute too," I added, my cheeks heating up. I didn't want her to think I was completely useless. "I'm an artist. I just finished a commission yesterday, which could be a big earner."

"An artist?" Morgan's delicate eyebrows climbed her forehead in interest. "Do you draw? Paint?"

"It's mostly digital," I shrugged. "But, yes, I do some painting. Acrylics, oils, watercolours. I'd be happy to show you sometime."

"Anyway," Daisy interrupted with a noise that sounded like her clearing her throat, "I'm sorry I can't be there myself, but these psychology lectures are fascinating. We're covering research methodologies for relationship studies today."

"Ah, yes. You're also a psychology student. How intriguing that must be," Morgan said, and I caught something calculating in her expression. "What sort of relationship studies?"

"Oh, various dynamics. Communication patterns, trust issues, and infidelity research. Actually, I'm working on a paper about married couples in close-knit communities — how living in proximity affects friendships. Is it best for friends to live close by, or for them to have a bit of distance?"

"What a good question. That sounds incredibly relevant to our little community here," Morgan said smoothly. "Modern relationships can be so... complex, can't they?"

"Absolutely. Right, I should dash. My next lecture starts in five minutes," Daisy said through the phone. "Jordan, don't keep Morgan any longer than need be. She's got things to do, just as you have. We can always figure out our neighbourhood watch responsibilities together later."

"I've got all the time in the world," Morgan said, her hand finding my arm again. "Don't worry about it. Once I've finished explaining everything, I'll let him get on with his... modern husband duties."

After Daisy said her goodbyes and hung up, Morgan settled back in her chair, pulling out a laminated rota sheet. I got the feeling that Daisy had been slightly wary of Morgan being here alone with me. She didn't seem to like it, but she had nothing to worry about. I made a mental note to reassure her about that later.

"Now then," Morgan said, her voice returning to that intimate tone, "Let's talk about what you and Daisy would be comfortable contributing. We try to keep things manageable. Nobody wants this to become a burden."

I studied the schedule, noting names paired together in neat handwriting. "What's the typical contribution?"

"Most couples take on watching duties from home perhaps once a fortnight, just keeping an eye on the street from your windows during designated evening hours. Very easy. You could even do it while watching the football." She traced a finger down the calendar. "Then actual patrols maybe once or twice a month, usually in pairs for safety, although some of the men are happy to do them alone."

"That seems reasonable," I said, though something about her emphasis on 'pairs' made my pulse quicken. I thought of Paul last night, walking with Bluebell. Was that why he'd been so attentive? Was he doing a patrol?

"Wonderful. Now, for your first few patrols, I'd recommend partnering with someone experienced." Morgan added before I could ask about Paul. Her smile was perfectly innocent, but her eyes held something else entirely. "I'd be happy to show you the routes myself, or perhaps Corinne would be good company. She knows every corner of the rise."

I nodded, trying to ignore the implications of walking dark streets alone with either of these attractive women.

"And Daisy," Morgan continued, studying the rota thoughtfully, "She might pair well with Tyler for her first patrol. He's very thorough, very... protective of our community members. Or Paul. He's quite knowledgeable about the area's security concerns. He usually takes their dog along for protection and checks the two paths."

That half-answered my question, but the thought of Daisy walking the neighbourhood alone with either man sent a strange thrill through me that I couldn't quite bring myself to analyse.

"And if Daisy is happy to join, when would we start?" I asked.

Morgan smiled, gathering her papers with deliberate slowness. "How about this weekend? Saturday evening might work well for your first watching duty. You could try just keeping an eye on things from your front windows between eight and ten. Nice and easy."

She stood, smoothing her blouse in a way that drew my attention back to the generous swell of her breasts beneath the thin fabric. "And perhaps next week we could arrange your first patrol. I'll check with Corinne about her availability and speak to Tyler and Paul, too."

"Got it," I nodded, trying not to stare at her chest. I could see the delicate stitching of a lace bra through the blouse, and the buttons gaped open again to show the caramel coloured contours of her curves. "I'll talk to Daisy later and we'll let you know."

"You have my number," she nodded and smiled, pointing at the contact sheet that she'd left on the table.

“I do. Thanks.”

As I walked her to the door, Morgan paused, her hand briefly touching my chest. "Jordan, I think you and Daisy are going to fit in perfectly here. Our little community has such wonderful opportunities for the right couples."

After she left, I stood in my hallway with a bundle of neighbourhood watch paperwork in my hands, wondering exactly what I'd just signed up for.

Map of Far Bridge Rise and Other Documents



FAR BRIDGE RISE NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH Complete Member Information Package Updated: October 2025

ENCLOSED DOCUMENTS:

Member Directory & Special Responsibilities (this document)

Far Bridge Rise Neighbourhood Map with Patrol Routes

Complete Contact Directory with Phone Numbers & Email Addresses

Monthly Meeting Schedule & Venue Rotation

Crime Prevention Checklist & Home Security Guidelines

Emergency Contact Procedures & Communication Protocols

Welcome to Far Bridge Rise!

This directory represents our committed community of residents who have chosen to take an active role in maintaining the safety, security, and unique character of our neighbourhood. Each member brings special talents and enthusiasm to our collective efforts. We believe that effective community

watch programs thrive when everyone contributes according to their individual strengths, interests, and particular special skills. Please review the roles and responsibilities outlined below, and don't hesitate to reach out to any coordinator if you have questions about participation levels or would like to explore different ways to contribute to our community's diverse activities.

COORDINATORS:

**Frank & Linda Petrosky (House 14) - Official Coordinators
“Community Liaison,” Meeting Minutes, Police Contact**

DEPUTY COORDINATORS:

**Tyler & Morgan Williams (House 6) - Recruitment & Training New
Member Integration, Patrol Scheduling, "Special Activities
Coordination"**

OPERATIONS:

**Kelly Morrison (House 23) - Meeting Host & Communications Event
Planning, "Large Group Social Activities," "Multi-Participant
Coordination"**

Paul & Corinne Hughes (House 1) - Surveillance & Equipment Specialists Camera Networks, "Discreet Observation Protocols," "Specialised Equipment Provision"

ACTIVE MEMBERS:

Russell & Charlotte Davies (House 11) - External Contact Management Visitor Screening, "Guest Integration," "Hospitality Coordination," "Gender Equality Consultants"

Marco & Angelica Romano (House 9) - Technology & Documentation Digital Systems, "Privacy Protection," "Activity Recording & Storage," "Gender Equality Consultants"

Margaret & Robert Sterling (House 4) - Senior Member Support "Veteran Engagement Programs," Historical Records, "Experience Sharing," "Cross-Orientation Activities"

PARTICIPATING MEMBERS:

**James & Emma Walsh (House 18) - Individual Rotation Management
"Sequential Participation Duties," "Alternating Responsibilities,"
Childcare Arrangements**

**Eleanor & Geoffrey Morris (House 21) - Observation Specialists
"Passive Monitoring," "Visual Demonstrations," "Discretion
Consultants"**

PROVISIONAL MEMBERS:

**Kendall & Michael Petrosky (House 14) - New Asset Development
"Guest Participation Organisers," "Enthusiasm Training," "Fresh
Perspective Integration"**

**Simon Clarke (House 7) - Special Physical Asset Recruitment "Unique
Qualification Assessment," "Ongoing Engagement Discussions"**

NEW MEMBERS:

**Jordan & Daisy Hoyland (House 8) - Probationary Status Orientation
Phase, "Compatibility Assessment Pending," "Lifestyle Suitability
Evaluation"**

SPECIALISATION GUIDE: Members are encouraged to explore activities matching their comfort levels and interests. Our community accommodates traditional partnership arrangements, alternative preferences, equipment-enhanced activities, group coordination, and flexible orientation approaches.

Important Confidentiality Reminder:

Our neighbourhood watch operates on the principle of mutual trust, absolute discretion, and respect for all speciality choices and privacy preferences. All members are expected to maintain strict confidentiality regarding internal activities and to demonstrate the mature judgment necessary for our continued success. We pride ourselves on being an exceptionally close-knit community where everyone looks out for one another in various innovative ways. New members will find there are numerous opportunities for deeper involvement across a full spectrum of activities as comfort levels and enthusiasm develop naturally over time.

For questions about specific roles, activity options, or to discuss participation preferences, please contact Tyler & Morgan Williams at your earliest convenience. Contact numbers and emails are provided on the attached directory sheet.

Chapter five

Chapter 5: Mischief on Far Bridge Rise

The afternoon sun was beginning to fade when I heard Daisy's key in the front door. I'd spent the better part of the day working around the house, and then spent the last half hour reading through the neighbourhood watch paperwork, digesting the detailed map of Far Bridge Rise, and trying to process exactly what I'd signed up for. The member directory with its carefully worded responsibilities sat open on the kitchen table alongside Morgan's contact list.

"Jordan?" Daisy called from the hallway. "I'm back!"

"In the kitchen," I replied, gathering the papers into a neater pile. "How were your lectures today?"

She appeared in the doorway carrying her psychology textbooks against her chest, and I felt that familiar flutter of appreciation at seeing her. Her strawberry blonde hair was pulled back in a neat ponytail that emphasised the elegant line of her neck, and her white cotton blouse was crisp despite the long day. The fabric was just sheer enough for me to make out the shadow of her bra underneath. Her navy trousers hugged her hips perfectly, and she'd kicked off her shoes somewhere in the hallway, leaving her barefoot.

"Fascinating, actually. We covered some groundbreaking research on community dynamics and social influence." She set her books down on the counter and came over to kiss my cheek, bringing with her the faint scent of her perfume mixed with the cool autumn air. "So these are all the neighbourhood watch materials you mentioned on the phone?"

"This is them," I said, watching as she picked up the welcome letter from Frank and Linda Petrosky. "I have to give it to them, they're well-organised."

Daisy read with her characteristic intensity, her full lower lip caught between her teeth in concentration, a habit I'd always found endearing. She

picked up the laminated map next, tracing the street layout with her finger.

"Look at this. They've got every house labelled with residents' names, the ones that are in the watch, at least. That's so helpful for newcomers like us." She leaned over the table to study it more closely, and I caught myself glancing at the way her shirt gaped slightly, revealing a tantalising glimpse of her cleavage.

I cleared my throat and focused on her face. "Morgan mentioned they'd like us to start with some basic duties. Nothing too demanding, maybe watching from our windows once a fortnight, the occasional patrol."

"That sounds perfectly reasonable." Daisy straightened and picked up the member directory, brushing an escaped strand of hair behind her ear. "Oh, this is interesting. Look at all these different roles and responsibilities."

She read through the list with the same academic focus she did with her psychology research. I found myself watching her face for reactions to the various special responsibilities listed, wondering if she thought any of them too much, but she seemed to take everything at face value.

"Everyone listed here seems to have their own jobs," she noted. "Even Kendall and Michael. It's nice when whole families get involved in community activities."

My phone rang before I could respond, startling us both. The caller ID showed a name I hadn't seen in weeks: Spencer.

"Spencer!" I answered, immediately brightening. "Hold on, let me put you on speaker so Daisy can say hello."

I pressed the speaker button, and Spencer's warm voice filled our kitchen.

"There we go," I said. "How are you?"

"I'm good! You're both there?" my best friend's voice came through the speaker clearly. "Elia's out with her friends, so it's just me at this end. How is everything? Are you enjoying the new house?"

"Spencer!" Daisy's face lit up with genuine pleasure, her whole posture brightening. "It's so good to hear from you. We're settling in great! The house is perfect, the neighbours are friendly, it's all good."

"That's fantastic. I have to say, it's been far too quiet on our street without you two. The place isn't the same."

"We miss you guys too," Daisy said, though I noticed a slight edge to her tone when she asked. She'd not mentioned to me that she was missing our old home and friends. "How's Elia doing? I haven't spoken to her in ages."

"She's very well, thanks for asking. As I said, she's out tonight, but she asked me to call. Earlier, we were talking about how much we miss having you both nearby."

Spencer and Elia had been our neighbours for nearly three years on our old street, the kind of close friends who made moving away genuinely difficult. Spencer worked in marketing for a tech firm, with dark hair and a carefully maintained beard, and the kind of stocky, broad-shouldered build that made him naturally popular with the ladies. He was one of those genuinely nice guys who remembered everyone's birthdays and never forgot to ask after your sick relatives. Elia was his perfect complement. Tiny, petite and graceful with her blonde hair that she'd recently begun dying pink at the tips, giving her an almost otherworldly quality. She worked as a mobile hairdresser, but she also had customers come to their home during the day, so she'd become Daisy's closest friend on the street.

We'd spent countless evenings together, sharing dinners and bottles of wine, talking about everything from work frustrations to vacation plans. They were the couple we'd automatically thought to call when we had good news to share, the ones whose house keys we exchanged for emergencies. Losing that valued closeness had been one of the hardest parts of moving to Far Bridge Rise.

"Would you be up for dinner tomorrow night?" Spencer continued. "We could drive over, see the new place properly, catch up like old times."

I glanced at Daisy, who was nodding enthusiastically despite that subtle tension I'd detected in her voice when she'd asked about Elia.

"That sounds brilliant," I said. "Daisy's practically jumping up and down here."

"Perfect. Seven-thirty work for you both? We'll bring wine, and Elia's been experimenting with that Italian cookbook you recommended, Daisy. She's eager to show off if you let her cook for you."

"Seven-thirty is perfect," Daisy replied, and I noticed how she perked up at the mention of being consulted about cooking. "Tell Elia I'm looking forward to seeing what she can rustle up."

"Will do. You'll have to show me round the neighbourhood so I can see where you're living and if it's up to the standards my best friends deserve."

"It definitely is," I said, glancing at the paperwork scattered across our kitchen table. "The neighbours have a neighbourhood watch, it's a close-knit community. You'll love it."

"Sounds good. Right, we'll see you both tomorrow evening then. I can't wait to catch up properly."

After we hung up, Daisy was beaming, any trace of that earlier edge completely gone.

"Spencer and Elia! It feels like ages since we've seen them properly. And Elia's cooking for us! Do you remember how nervous she used to get about hosting dinner parties?"

I smiled, remembering Elia's tendency to over-prepare for every social gathering, turning their kitchen into something resembling a bomb site. "She usually pulled it off in the end. Remember that paella disaster that somehow turned into the best meal we'd had all year?"

"God, yes. When she accidentally doubled the saffron and thought she'd ruined everything." Daisy laughed, already moving toward the kitchen

cupboards. "I should check what wine we have. And we'll need to tidy up. Elia will want the full house tour."

We spent the rest of the early evening preparing for Spencer and Elia's visit, Daisy bustling around with the kind of energy she always found when someone was coming to visit. Over a simple dinner of pasta and salad, we discussed the neighbourhood watch materials further, with Daisy taking particular interest in the patrol schedules and community integration.

After dinner, she disappeared upstairs for a shower while I settled in the living room with my iPad and a pair of headphones, trying to find some inspiration for a new project. I'd been listening to a mellowing instrumental playlist, hoping the ambient soundscape might spark some creative ideas. With no immediate commissions on the horizon, I needed to generate some spec work, something to keep my portfolio fresh and my skills sharp.

I found myself sketching absent-minded geometric forms in my notepad, then pausing to consider more ambitious projects. Still-life work had always been a staple for artists between commissions. It kept your skills sharp to simply observe and draw. Simple arrangements of household objects, studies in light and shadow, explorations of form and texture. The challenge was making them interesting enough to be portfolio-worthy rather than just academic exercises.

My mind drifted, somewhat inevitably, to the idea of asking Daisy to pose for some figure studies. Not anything overtly sexual. Some tasteful artistic nudes, studies in form and light. She had beautiful lines and elegant proportions that would translate well to charcoal or graphite. But I also knew her well enough to know she'd refuse. Daisy was comfortable with her body in private but had always been self-conscious about being studied so intently, even by me.

Perhaps I could start with something less intimidating. Clothed portraits, studies of her reading or working on her psychology research. Then, slowly build up to more revealing subject matter.

Because of my headphones, I didn't hear Daisy come downstairs. She appeared in the room in her fluffy white dressing gown, and I felt my breath

catch slightly. Her golden hair was still damp and twisted up in a loose knot, with rebellious strands escaping to frame her face. The shower had left her skin flushed and dewy, and I could see droplets of water still clinging to the hollow of her throat and her delicate collarbones. The robe was tied loosely at her waist, showing off the curves of her hips and the swell of her breasts beneath the soft fabric.

"I forgot to close the curtains earlier," she said, moving toward the large front windows. "I don't want to give the neighbours an unintentional show, as you mentioned last time."

I watched with approval as she drew the curtains closed, shutting out the dark street beyond. I hadn't explicitly told her about Paul seeing her while walking his dog, but she'd obviously heard what I'd said about being more careful. It pleased me that she was being more responsible now, taking my concerns seriously, but I also felt a tiny twinge of disappointment. What was wrong with me? I shouldn't want anyone to see my wife naked.

"Good thinking," I said. "Especially now we know that the neighbourhood watch is often... well... watching."

"The clue is in the title," she giggled and turned from the windows with a mischievous smile, then, before I could react, she loosened the belt of her robe and let it fall open, giving me a deliberate, playful flash of her naked body. Her breasts were still damp from the shower, nipples peaked from the cooling air, and the gentle curve of her waist led down to the soft little tuft of light hair between her thighs. The glimpse lasted only a second before she pulled the robe closed again, but it was enough to send heat racing through my veins.

"However, you're not in the neighbourhood watch just yet," she said with a laugh. "So you still get a flash."

I was about to respond with something appropriately appreciative when the doorbell rang.

We both froze. It was nearly eight o'clock on a Thursday evening, late for casual visitors.

"Expecting anyone?" Daisy asked, pulling her dressing gown tighter around herself, suddenly self-conscious.

"No one at all," I replied, already moving toward the door.

Through the frosted glass, I could make out a tall, familiar silhouette. Tyler.

I opened the door to find him standing on our doorstep, holding what appeared to be a folder and smiling apologetically.

"Hi Jordan. I'm so sorry to drop by unannounced. I hope this isn't a bad time?"

"Not at all," I said, though I was acutely aware of Daisy standing behind me in nothing but her dressing gown. "Come in."

Tyler stepped inside, and I caught the way his eyes briefly swept over Daisy before settling back on my face. It was subtle — the glance of a man who knew how to look without seeming to stare. Daisy had pulled her robe tightly closed and was holding it in place with both hands, but Tyler's quick assessment had clearly taken in her damp hair, flushed skin, and the apparent fact that she was fresh from the shower.

"Daisy," he said with that warm smile of his. "You look lovely this evening. I hope I'm not interrupting anything important."

"Not at all," she replied, though I noticed the slight colour in her cheeks deepen. "I was just getting ready for bed."

"I really am sorry for the intrusion," Tyler continued, holding up the folder in his hands. "I was doing a patrol tonight — we try to keep random schedules to stay unpredictable — and I thought I spotted a couple of kids messing around near the empty Henderson house. Right across the road."

He moved further into our hallway, closer to Daisy, and she stepped back, closer to me, perhaps feeling embarrassed, caught in only her dressing gown.

"Kids?" I asked. "What were they doing?"

"Hard to say exactly. I only caught a glimpse before they scattered, but it looked like they might have been trying to get into the back garden. It could have been completely innocent — teenagers taking a shortcut or looking for somewhere to smoke. But given that the property's been empty for months, I thought it was worth checking out."

"Okay," I nodded. "I'll keep an eye out for the rest of the night."

Tyler's expression was serious, concerned. "The thing is, I think they've gone now, but I'm not entirely sure. They could be hiding somewhere, waiting for me to leave. I was wondering if you might be willing to join me for a quick patrol around the perimeter? Two sets of eyes are always better than one, and it would be good for you to get a feel for the actual patrol routes anyway."

I glanced back at Daisy, who was watching our conversation with interest, then back to the tall black man standing in our hallway. "What do we do if we find them still hanging around?"

"I'm fairly sure they're gone, but not certain. If we run into them, we just tell them to move on. Any trouble and we call the police." Tyler shifted the folder to his other hand. "It would only take fifteen or twenty minutes, just a quick circuit to make sure everything's secure. Consider it your unofficial introduction to neighbourhood watch duties."

The request seemed perfectly reasonable, and there was something appealing about the idea of actually doing something active rather than just reading through paperwork. Plus, it would give me a chance to see the cul-de-sac properly after dark and get a sense of the patrol routes Tyler had mentioned.

"Of course," I said. "Just let me grab a jacket."

"Excellent." Tyler smiled. "And Daisy, don't worry, I'll have him back safe and sound before you know it."

I grabbed a jacket from the hallway cupboard while Tyler waited at our front door, his attention seeming to drift between the conversation and

occasional glances toward Daisy.

"I must say, Jordan, you're a very lucky man," Tyler said as we stepped out into the cool evening air, "Daisy is gorgeous. Back before I started dating Morgan, I had a thing for blondes like her."

"Umm, thanks." I cleared my throat, not sure how to react to that, but Tyler didn't elaborate further on his taste in women. Instead, he began explaining the basics of the patrol. The streets were dark in between the widely spaced streetlights, creating pools of amber illumination connected by shadows.

"The key is to look relaxed and natural," Tyler said as we walked toward the main road. "We're not trying to be intimidating or obvious about what we're doing. Most of our work is simply being present, being visible, letting potential troublemakers know that people are paying attention."

We moved at an easy pace along the pavement, Tyler pointing out the paths that led out into the woods and the park beyond the cul-de-sac, and explaining sight lines. "That's Kelly's house there at number twenty-three. She often patrols the path herself because it runs next to her house. She's very dedicated to community safety. If you head down the path next to her house, there's a small rear access path that leads around the backs of all the houses, right up to the Petrovskys' at fourteen. Where Kendall and her family live."

I noticed how he emphasised Kendall's name slightly, though I couldn't read any particular meaning into it.

"The path also leads behind the empty Henderson property," Tyler continued. "Because it's empty, I fear it's a natural target for mischief-makers."

As we approached the end of our part of the cul-de-sac and Kelly's house, Tyler slowed his pace and lowered his voice slightly. He paused at the front gate, studying the darkened windows. "What I'm thinking is that we should split up for maximum coverage. I'll take the front and eastern side, check the main approaches. Would you be comfortable taking the back garden

path and western perimeter? It's all quite straightforward. Just look for any signs of disturbance, broken fencing, that sort of thing."

I felt a small thrill of nervous excitement. This was real neighbourhood watch work, not just reading through paperwork and member directories.

"That makes sense," I said. "How long does it take to walk?"

"Ten or fifteen minutes should do it. Take your time, let your eyes adjust to the darkness. Sometimes you'll spot things that aren't immediately obvious." Tyler checked his watch. "Shall we say meet back here at twenty? If either of us spots anything concerning, we raise the alarm with this."

He handed me a whistle and a small flashlight from his jacket pocket. "Don't use the torch unless you absolutely have to. It ruins your night vision. But it's good to have just in case, and the whistle is only to be blown if you're in trouble and need help. Any neighbour that hears it will come to your aid."

I nodded and tucked the two items into my jacket pockets. After I watched Tyler walk away, back towards the main cul-de-sac, I made my way around the side of Kelly's property toward the rear path. I couldn't shake the feeling that this felt like more than just checking for teenage troublemakers. That I was being initiated fully into the community watch program.

I found the small path — almost invisible in the dark — that trailed to the right, away from Kelly's back garden, stretching away into darkness toward the tree line of the country park beyond the end of the cul-de-sac. I moved carefully along the perimeter, tracking the back gardens of the houses opposite ours, checking for signs of disturbance as Tyler had described. Everything seemed undisturbed.

My route took me behind house after house as I worked my way methodically around the street. Most were dark, their occupants settled in for the evening, but I could see the occasional glow of television screens through drawn curtains.

I was approaching the back of house fourteen at the far end of the rise — the Petrosky residence — when a light suddenly came on in what appeared to be the living room. I instinctively stepped into the shadow of a large oak tree, not wanting to be seen lurking behind their back garden.

Through the large window, I could see Kendall moving around the room. The young woman who had almost been run over the other day was wearing nothing but a red towel wrapped around her body, clearly fresh from the shower, her long dark hair damp and tousled, much like Daisy had been earlier. I knew I should look away, continue my patrol, but something kept me frozen in place.

She moved easily, completely unaware she was being observed. The towel was tucked securely around her chest, but it barely reached mid-thigh, revealing her long, toned legs. She picked up a hairdryer from somewhere off to the side and began drying her hair, tilting her head this way and that as she worked.

I should have moved on. Every rational part of my brain told me this was wrong, an invasion of her privacy. But I remained motionless in the shadows, transfixed by the intimate domestic scene playing out before me.

As Kendall continued blow-drying her hair, raising her arms to lift sections, the towel shifted and loosened. She seemed to notice and paused, reaching to adjust it, but as she moved, the scarlet cloth simply slipped from her body and fell to the floor.

My breath caught in my throat. Kendall stood completely naked in the brightly lit room, her young body illuminated like a classical sculpture. Her skin was a beautiful dusky tone that spoke of her mixed-race heritage, smooth and flawless in the warm lamplight. Her dark hair fell in damp waves past her shoulders, framing her delicate features and large, expressive eyes.

Her breasts were small and perfectly proportioned to her petite frame, with dark nipples that stood out against her olive-toned skin. Her waist was narrow, emphasising the gentle curve of her hips, and her legs seemed

impossibly long for someone of her slight stature. Between her thighs, her pussy was completely smooth and bare, clearly carefully maintained.

She made no immediate move to retrieve the towel, apparently comfortable with her nudity in the privacy of her own home. Instead, she continued with her hair, completely unaware of my presence in her back garden. I felt my cock harden in my pants as I stood there, enjoying the sight of the young woman's complete nakedness. I shouldn't be standing here. This was wrong.

But just as I was about to force myself to look away, a young man entered the room. He was tall and athletic, someone I'd never seen before. Kendall's face lit up with obvious pleasure at seeing him, her body language shifting from relaxed to obvious excitement.

She dropped the hairdryer onto the sofa and they immediately embraced and kissed passionately, her naked body pressed against his fully clothed form. I watched, transfixed, as he stepped back, his hands began exploring her body — cupping her small breasts, his thumbs brushing over her nipples, then sliding down to touch between her legs. She arched against his touch as he slipped his fingers inside her, before her own hands moved to his chest and began working at his belt buckle.

His hand was moving quickly between her thighs, fingering her as she dropped his pants, and I felt my eyes widen as his cock — surprisingly large for such a young man — fell free. Kendall dropped to her knees, looking up at him with a mischievous grin and then took his flaccid length into her mouth. My heart was hammering behind my ribs as I watched her begin to suck him to hardness. I needed to go. I was being a voyeur, even worse than Paul, the other night. But I didn't. I stood there watching until she finally pulled away, her saliva coating his long, thick erection. Were they going to fuck now?

The young man took her hand, leading her to the sofa, but just as she started to bend over the back of it, Kendall glanced toward the window. Her eyes seemed to scan the darkness beyond the glass, and I quickly pressed myself back against the oak tree, my pulse quickening with fear that I'd been spotted.

I held my breath, remaining perfectly still in the shadows. The night was so dark that I reassured myself there was no possible way she could have seen me. After what felt like an eternity, I dared to look past the tree, seeing Kendall standing at the window now, looking out. Then she took hold of the curtains and drew them closed, cutting off my view completely.

I stood frozen there for several more seconds, processing what I'd witnessed. Kendall's young, slim body had been absolutely breathtaking — every subtle curve perfectly formed, and the way she'd sucked the man's cock... She wasn't inexperienced; that much was obvious.

Guilt washed over me as I forced myself to continue my patrol route. Walking around to the front of the house, I noticed that the driveway was empty. Frank and Linda's cars were nowhere to be seen. They must have been out for the evening, leaving Kendall free to entertain her mysterious visitor.

"Jordan!" Tyler's voice called softly from somewhere ahead. "How did you get on?"

I looked up to see him approaching down the road, his patrol apparently completed as well. I tried to compose my expression, hoping the darkness would hide any telltale signs of what I'd witnessed.

"All quiet on my end," I said, proud that my voice sounded steady. "No signs of any disturbance around the Henderson property or anywhere else for that matter."

"Excellent. Same here on the front end." Tyler fell into step beside me as we began walking back toward our houses. "I think those kids, whoever they were, have probably moved on. Sometimes the mere presence of patrollers is enough to discourage mischief."

We walked in comfortable silence for a few moments, but my mind kept drifting back to Kendall. I wondered if Tyler, or anyone else, had ever seen something like that. I couldn't be that lucky, could I? As Daisy and I had learned, knowing that Far Bridge Rise had a neighbourhood watch, wouldn't everyone be more careful?

"Congratulations on completing your first patrol," Tyler said as we reached our end of the cul-de-sac. "It's helpful that you know that rear path. There's one on the other side too, behind our houses and the main road. Anyway, it's good to have you on the team."

"Thanks," I replied, making a note to check out the path he'd mentioned. I didn't know it was there. "You're right about it being good to know where all these little pathways are."

Tyler smiled at that. "They're for rear access to the property, in case of emergencies, but they're also a risk when it comes to kids making mischief. So, it's good to know they're there and to patrol them regularly. That's the thing with our neighbourhood watch. You learn things about your neighbours, about your community, that you never would have discovered otherwise."

There was something in his tone that made me wonder if he knew more than he was letting on. But before I could analyse it further, we'd reached our respective driveways.

"Right then," Tyler said, pulling out his keys. "Keep the flashlight and whistle for next time. Thanks again for the assistance tonight. I'll let Frank and Morgan know how well you handled yourself."

"No problem at all. Good night, Tyler."

"Good night, Jordan. Sleep well."

As I watched him disappear into his house next door, I stood for a moment in the cool night air, trying to digest everything that had just happened and everything he'd said. I was beginning to wonder about the exact nature of our neighbours. There were too many questions forming, too many odd comments, too many coincidences.

The image of Kendall's young, naked body refused to leave my thoughts as I quietly let myself back into our house, where Daisy was undoubtedly waiting to hear about my evening of community service. Should I tell her

what I'd seen and about my growing suspicions about the real purpose of the Far Bridge Rise neighbourhood watch?

Thursday Research Notes: Psychology of Kinks and Extra-Marital Relationships

Today's lecture on alternative sexual behaviours... Dr Richardson's question about why people seek kinks outside their primary relationships. Is it compensation for something missing? The statistics were fascinating. 34% of affairs happen within social circles, which makes sense when you think about it. Trust already established, opportunity, familiarity...

Selterman's eight variables keep rolling around in my head. Anger at partner, wanting more sex, craving intimacy, low commitment, desire for autonomy, feeling neglected, wanting variety... That last one is particularly interesting. Why do people in seemingly happy marriages still crave variety? Is monogamy actually unnatural or just poorly executed?

The kink connection is what really intrigues me, though. Affairs provide a safe space for sexual experimentation without judgment from the primary partner. The taboo nature of the affair itself heightens arousal, the forbidden fruit effect. Makes me wonder about power dynamics too... secretive relationships often manifest as dominance play, BDSM elements, exhibitionism, voyeurism, lots to explore here...

Close-knit communities really do create perfect conditions for this stuff, and so I'm going to try to find out if there's ever been any affairs on Far Bridge Rise. I picked up on some weird vibes at the neighbourhood watch meeting, and I have some theories, but I need to be careful and not offend anyone. Maybe if I befriend Morgan and a few of the other neighbours... For research purposes, obviously.

My essay is due next Friday. 4000 words on the topic of alternative sexual arrangements in married couples. And who knows... Far Bridge Rise might

provide more material than I initially thought...

Chapter six

Chapter 6: Posing Questions

Watery autumn sunlight filtered through our bedroom curtains, casting a warm glow across Daisy's face as she stood in front of the mirror. I stretched, trying to work the knots of sleep out of my muscles, and sat up slowly. Daisy must have been awake for a while already. She was already dressed, moving around the bedroom with that purposeful energy she brought to workday mornings. But now she paused at the foot of the bed, looking down at me with an amused expression.

"You were certainly enthusiastic last night," she said, turning to the mirror again and adjusting her blouse. "I don't think I've seen you that worked up in weeks."

Heat crept up my neck as memories of my frantic lovemaking flashed through my mind, how horny I'd been, how desperately I'd needed sex. But underneath those memories lurked the real reason for my arousal: the image of Kendall's naked body in that brightly lit window, every curve and intimate detail burned into my consciousness.

"Sometimes I just look at you and think to myself how lucky I am," I said, trying to keep my voice casual. "It's not my fault you're so sexy and desirable."

Daisy smiled at that, moving to the bed to kiss me goodbye. "Well, I certainly felt desired last night. Try to channel that energy into something productive today, maybe? Have you heard back from the computer game company? Any more commissions on the horizon?"

"Maybe," I shrugged. "We'll see."

After she left for work, I found myself alone with my thoughts and a nagging restlessness I couldn't shake. Sarah still hadn't responded to my messages from earlier in the week, and my portfolio needed fresh material. I tried to relax, browsing the web, catching up on news, and even checking the latest updates on DemureMillieGrace's blog. But the need to do

something productive wouldn't go away, so I decided to work on some sketches. Maybe getting back to the fundamentals might help clear my head and possibly generate some spec work worth showing potential clients.

I gathered my sketchpad and supplies from my small makeshift studio, but when I reached for my pencil case, I found it nearly empty. Several of the good drawing pencils — my 2H, 4B, and 6B, to name just a few — were all down to unusable stubs. I'd been putting off replacing them for ages, telling myself I'd wait until a new commission came through, but inspiration couldn't wait for financial security.

The local art supply shop was a twenty-minute ride away, nestled in a small row of independent stores that somehow survived despite the nearby retail park. I sent Sarah another email, politely reminding her of my availability for work, and then grabbed my jacket and wallet.

Daisy had the car, so I jumped on the bus, and the journey gave me time to think, though my thoughts kept circling back to the same uncomfortable territory. Every time I tried to focus on potential art projects or commission strategies, my mind would drift to the night before: Kendall's naked body, the way she'd sucked the stranger's cock, completely unaware she was being watched. The memory sent an unwelcome surge of arousal through me, accompanied by an equally unwelcome surge of guilt.

The art shop was busy for a Friday afternoon, mostly with students stocking up on supplies. I moved through the aisles mechanically, selecting pencils, a new eraser, and some blending tools I'd been meaning to replace. The familiar ritual of choosing materials usually calmed me, but today, even this simple task felt complicated by my distracted state.

By the time I caught the return bus, laden with a bag of supplies that had cost more than I'd intended to spend, it was mid-afternoon. The afternoon had turned overcast, and the ride home felt longer than the journey out. I found myself rehearsing a telephone conversation with Sarah about potential work, trying to strike the right balance between availability and desperation.

I turned the corner from the bus stop on the main road onto Far Bridge Rise, my mind now occupied with what I might draw, when I spotted a familiar figure ahead. The worst possible person I could run into was walking toward me — Kendall — and she wasn't alone.

The young man from the night before was with her, her hand firmly in his. He must have stayed overnight, which meant Frank and Linda had either been out or were surprisingly liberal about their nineteen-year-old daughter's romantic arrangements.

They weren't the only familiar figures on the cul-de-sac. Walking toward them from the opposite direction were Corinne and Paul, with Bluebell trotting alongside on her lead. Corinne's vibrant red hair caught the afternoon light, her athletic figure shown off by a form-hugging sports top that showed a sliver of her toned abdomen where it didn't quite reach the waistband of her fitted leggings. Even from a distance, I could see the confident way she moved that came from someone who took excellent care of their body.

Paul walked beside her with a more measured pace, his stocky frame solid and broad. He was dressed in more casual attire but still presentable. His dark hair had touches of grey at the temples, and despite not being a fitness fan like his wife, something about his posture said he was equally confident in his own skin.

The four of them converged, the young stranger bending to pet Bluebell, and I found myself slowing my pace, not really wanting to draw Kendall's attention. I crossed the road to the other side, glancing across to see them talking animatedly and kept moving, hoping they'd be too distracted to notice me as I got closer.

Kendall was doing most of the chatting, her hands moving expressively as she gestured between her companion and the more mature couple. She looked radiant in the afternoon light, her olive skin glowing, and it was hard not to picture her body again. She was wearing a flowing sundress that clung to her lithe figure in all the right places, the fabric dancing around her long legs as she moved. Her dark hair fell in loose waves over her

shoulders, then fluttered as a gust of wind breezed down the road, throwing a few scattered leaves into the air.

The young man beside her appeared increasingly nervous as the conversation progressed. He kept running his hand through his dark hair, shifting his weight from foot to foot in a way that suggested he was anxious to leave. Despite his evident athleticism — broad shoulders filling out his rock T-shirt, lean build that spoke of regular exercise or a physical job — there was something boyish about his demeanour that made him seem younger than his probable twenty-something years.

Then, something struck me as odd, though I couldn't put a finger on why. Paul and Corinne seemed to be asking questions — I could see their heads tilting with interest, their body language suggesting they were sizing up the young man in some specific way. Were they vetting him? Checking if he was suitable boyfriend material for their neighbour's daughter?

Just as I was getting close enough to overhear potentially, the strangest thing happened. Paul nodded decisively, said something that made Corinne smile, and then he and Corinne began walking away with the young man between them while Kendall remained where she was, watching them go with a smile on her face. It was almost as if she had successfully completed some kind of transaction. The whole exchange had lasted perhaps two minutes, but there was just something that felt... weird. Off, in a way I didn't understand.

It was then that Kendall spotted me as I walked past on the other side of the street, her face breaking into a warm smile that sent an uncomfortable wave of emotions through me. Here was the same woman I'd watched through her window the night before, now fully clothed and walking toward me with a friendly smile that told me she hadn't seen me hiding behind the tree.

"Jordan!" she called out, her voice carrying that slightly husky quality that I remembered from the time I'd helped dress her graze after the near-accident. "It's nice to see you out and about. Been shopping?"

"Um, yes. Just some art supplies," I managed, shifting the bag to my other hand, hoping my voice sounded steadier than it felt. Looking at her now,

once again I found it impossible not to imagine her as she'd appeared in that window the night before.

The sundress she wore was a soft yellow that complemented her dusky skin beautifully, the fabric clinging to her small breasts in a way that made it obvious she wasn't wearing a bra. The neckline was modest enough for public wear, but knowing what lay beneath made me look downwards, past her body to her feet. Even as I did, I couldn't help but admire her long legs. They seemed even longer in daylight, toned and smooth, disappearing beneath the dress's flowing hemline that danced around her mid-thighs with each step.

"I forgot, you're an artist," she smiled. "What are you working on?"

"Nothing right now," I managed to say, finding my voice as she stopped in front of me. I forced myself to meet her gaze, and suddenly, the image of her kneeling before the stranger, those full lips wrapped around his cock, hit me with such intensity that I felt heat rush to my face. I tried to focus on something else — anything else — but my treacherous imagination kept supplying details: her hands on his body, the sounds she must have made, the way she would have looked up at him with those large, expressive dark eyes as she sucked his cock.

"Are you okay?" she asked, her eyes narrowing with concern. She'd sensed my discomfort.

"Yes, thanks," I replied, forcing myself to maintain eye contact while fighting off visions of her naked form writhing beneath her young lover. If he'd stayed over, they'd probably been fucking all night. "Just a little distracted. Trying to plan the next art piece in my head."

Kendall laughed, a sound that was both innocent and somehow knowing. "Maybe you could draw me? There should be plenty of inspiration in Far Bridge Rise. Look at the colours of the leaves on the trees." She glanced around, leading my eyes to the trees that dotted the pavements.

"I could draw something seasonal," I nodded, then decided to broach the subject of the young man. "Was that your boyfriend you were with?"

Kendall looked back in the direction where Corinne and Paul had disappeared with the young man. "Oh, no. That's just a friend of mine. Jake — he's an electrician. He did some work on my parents' house a few weeks ago, and Corinne mentioned she's got a... socket that needs fixing... in their kitchen. I thought I'd introduce them."

The explanation sounded perfectly reasonable, except for what I'd seen last night, which told me he was definitely more than a friend. "That's very thoughtful of you. If we need any electrical work done, I know how to ask."

"Well, I do like to help people connect," she said, her dark eyes sparkling with what might have been amusement. "That's the beauty of living in such a tight-knit community as we have here. You'd be surprised how much people have in common once you get them talking." She tilted her head, studying me with an intensity that made me uncomfortably aware that she was assessing me in some way. "So... what kind of art do you do, anyway?"

"Digital illustration mostly. Fantasy, gaming, that sort of thing." I was glad for the sudden change of subject back to the supplies in my hand. What she'd said about people connecting felt slightly... weird.

"Awesome," she said, stepping slightly closer. "Well, as I said earlier, I'd be happy to pose for you sometime, if you ever need a model. I've done some modelling before — nothing professional, I was just helping Angelica out. You might have met her at the neighbourhood meeting. She works in fashion."

I did remember Angelica, but I wasn't thinking about her right then. The suggestion of Kendall posing for me, of having legitimate reason to study every curve and line of her body, sent a surge of arousal through me so intense I had to shift my bag to a more strategic position, covering the growing bulge in my jeans.

"I'll bear that in mind. I should probably head home," I said, desperately needing to escape before I said something that revealed just how affected I was by this conversation. "Daisy and I have friends coming over tonight, and she'll expect me to have the house presentable."

Kendall laughed, a sound that was both warm and slightly teasing. "Ah, yes, the dutiful house husband. Daisy's got you well trained, hasn't she? Making sure everything's perfect while she's out conquering the working world."

There was something in her tone — not quite mocking, but definitely amused — that made me feel both defensive and oddly aroused at the same time.

"She's not just working," I said, feeling a need to defend our arrangement. "Daisy's finishing her master's degree in psychology while working as a legal assistant. She's got a lot to balance. And I'm working too — my art commissions pay pretty well."

The defensiveness in my voice was obvious, and I could see Kendall register it with interest. Her dark eyes sparkled with what might have been amusement at my reaction.

"Of course," she said smoothly. "I didn't mean to suggest otherwise. It's actually quite admirable how supportive you two are of each other's ambitions." She paused, tilting her head slightly. "So these friends coming over tonight — are they local?"

"Spencer and Elia, kind of. We've known them for years. They're our old neighbours from where we used to live. They're driving up to see the new place."

"How lovely," Kendall said, and there was something in her tone that suggested genuine interest. "Are they married as well?"

"They are. They have two young children, so they like to get out now and again." I didn't know why she was so curious, or why I was so eager to answer. I shifted the art supply bag again, using it as both a shield and a reminder of my excuse to leave. "Which is why I really should head home. There's still quite a bit to do before they arrive."

"Of course," Kendall said, but she didn't immediately step back to let me pass. Instead, she seemed to be studying me with that same assessing look I'd noticed earlier. "Well, I hope you have a wonderful evening with them."

And do remember what I said about the modelling — I'm quite serious about the offer. You have my number, right?"

"I do." I wasn't sure if it was just me or if everything about this conversation felt loaded with subtext I didn't quite understand. No. It was just me, overthinking everything because I'd seen her naked last night. "I should really get going," I said again, taking a small step toward home. "Lots to do, as I mentioned."

"Of course. Busy house husband duties await." Her tone was teasing again, but not unkind. "I do hope Daisy appreciates how well you take care of her."

"She does," I said, though something about the comment made me feel oddly defensive again.

"I'm sure she does." Kendall stepped back finally, giving me space to pass. "Enjoy your evening, Jordan. And don't forget — call me if you need anything at all."

As I walked away, I could feel her eyes on me, watching my every step with that same assessing look she'd worn throughout our conversation. The weight of her gaze lingered even after I'd turned the corner toward our front door, and it took considerable willpower not to glance back over my shoulder.

I fumbled with my keys, my mind cycling between inappropriate images of her naked body and confusion about the undercurrents in everything she'd said. The bag of art supplies felt heavy in my hand as I closed the door behind me, but not nearly as heavy as the weight of secrets I was already carrying.

The Power and Paradox of Being Seen

Home and Heart

A blog by @DemureMillieGrace

Today's musings stem from a conversation with a neighbour who mentioned how he "appreciated" my new autumn dress. It got me thinking about the complex dance between being desired and being in control of that desire.

There's something undeniably thrilling about catching a man's eye — that moment when you feel truly seen as beautiful, desirable, worthy of lingering glances. It's intoxicating, isn't it? The way his gaze follows the curve of your silhouette, how he stumbles slightly over his words. Pure feminine power.

But here's where it gets complicated: some days that attention feels like a warm embrace, other days like an unwelcome intrusion. The difference? Choice.

I've noticed that when I deliberately choose clothes that flatter — the wrap dress that hugs just right, the blouse that hints at décolletage — I feel empowered by male attention. It's my power being exercised. But when I'm simply existing in yoga pants and a jumper, yet still feel assessed and catalogued? That's when admiration becomes a burden.

Is intentionally dressing to provoke that spark exhibitionism? Perhaps. But I'd argue it's reclaiming agency over our own sexuality. We're saying: "Yes, look. But know that I wanted you to look."

The suburban housewife aesthetic shouldn't preclude sensuality. In fact, there's something deliciously subversive about being the neighbour who makes men forget their shopping lists, all while discussing school runs and garden centres.

The male gaze isn't inherently problematic—it's the lack of female consent and control that creates discomfort. When we dress with intention, we transform from object to curator of desire.

After all, what's more empowering than knowing exactly the effect you have?

Yours in respect and empowerment,

Millie Grace

Comments disabled - some conversations are better had in person

Chapter seven

Chapter 7: Between Friends

Inside, the house was quiet except for the low hum of the fridge and the faint ticking of the hallway clock. I let my shopping bag thunk onto the kitchen counter, pushing all thoughts of Kendall and her electrician friend and mentally lining up everything I needed to do ahead of our friends' visit later.

Routine steadied me. I wiped down the counters, gathered the breakfast and dinner bowls, loaded the dishwasher, and wiped down the chrome of the taps and sink. Clearing a cluttered countertop provided a small, tangible satisfaction. I gathered the loose pencils I'd left out and stacked this morning's stray post neatly on the hall table, checking the time — just after four. Daisy was probably on her way home now.

Back in my makeshift studio, I lay out my new pencils and sketchpad. I tried to focus — roughing out an idea for a fantasy piece, the kind Sarah usually liked to see in my sample pack. But instead of elven armour or winding forest paths, what appeared on the page was the long, sinewy outline of a young woman standing in a shaft of light. I drew the slender line of Kendall's thigh, the proud arc of her hip, filled in the curve of a breast, lips parted in a smile that was almost taunting.

Daisy's voice from my memory: "Try to channel that energy into something productive today, will you?" I grinned, half-wistful, erasing the shape of Kendall's breast, trying for something less explicit. But the erotic feeling stuck, her body imprinted in the back of my mind, no matter how I tried to focus on something more professional.

I checked my email. Nothing from Sarah, not even a receipt or an auto-reply. My phone buzzed instead:

Leaving now xx, from Daisy. Typical Daisy — concise, efficient, a little string of kisses at the end out of habit more than passion. I texted Spencer.

Looking forward to seeing you guys. Daisy's got me tidying the house.

I waited for a reply, hoping some banter would lift me out of my head, but all I got in return was, Good man. Looking forward to it.

With time to spare, I decided to give the living room another quick once-over. I straightened the cushions, then vacuumed the hall, cleaned the mirror, and put away the laundry Daisy had left on the stairs, making sure not to leave any bras on show this time.

Daisy arrived soon after, her small car laden with grocery bags and the clinking sound of glass bottles. She kicked the door shut behind her, her cheeks pink from the cool evening air.

“I went a bit overboard,” she said, juggling a bottle of sauvignon blanc in one hand and a six-pack of craft beer in the other. “It’s Friday, no work, no lectures tomorrow, and I figured we could have a proper catch-up without rationing the wine this time.”

I took the rest of the bags from her and set them on the kitchen island. She looked relaxed for the first time all week, her hair unpinned from its usual neat twist and spilling loose around her shoulders.

“That sounds like a plan,” I said, smiling. “I, on the other hand, have cleaned the entire house and made it as presentable as I can for our guests.”

She put on a mock expression of awe before leaning up to kiss me quickly. “You are the dream husband.” She set the wine on the counter and began loosening the cork, humming while she worked.

My mood had shifted as soon as Daisy got home, pulling my thoughts away from the temptation that was Kendall. I stared at my beautiful, blonde-haired wife, wondering what the hell was going on in my head to be distracted by our young neighbour. I had everything I needed, right here in this woman.

A knock on the door yanked me from my thoughts.

“They’re here!” Daisy said, the cork finally popping free at almost the same moment as the knock. She poured a generous amount of wine into two

glasses, thrust one into my hand, and took a hearty sip of her own. “Perfect timing.”

Spencer was the first through the door. He was a tall, broad-shouldered force of nature whose presence seemed to fill the hallway nearly before he’d crossed the threshold. His hair was coal-black, cropped tight on the sides and left just long enough across the top to be stylish. The perfect, short-trimmed beard along his jaw only made him look more dashing, as if he’d stepped straight out of a high-end whiskey advert.

“Elia, it’s a shoes-off kind of place,” he called back with a grin after looking at his surroundings, already slipping out of his Chelsea boots. “Our friends are posh now. Upmarket suburbians.”

Elia’s laugh was a soft, silvery thing as she tottered in behind him, the top of her head barely clearing Spencer’s shoulder. She was tiny, delicate rather than fragile, with a petite frame under a pale jumper and a tiny denim miniskirt, her platinum hair in a perfect shoulder-length bob. “Of course. No dirt allowed in Daisy’s new kingdom,” she said, slipping her heels neatly by the door. Her eyes were a pale, intelligent blue; her movements, quick and purposeful. There was something almost elfin about her. Cute rather than overtly sexy, sharp as a tack beneath her gentle exterior.

“This place is great,” Spencer grinned, handing me a bottle of red, gazing around the kitchen as he joined us. “We thought we’d bring something decent. I don’t know whether they do normal wine out here in middle-class-ville, or if it’s all Champagne and shit like that.”

Daisy laughed, ushering Elia into the living room, already talking about the move, the neighbourhood, the joys and challenges of settling somewhere new. Within minutes, the four of us fell into the kind of comfortable conversation that only old friends could manage — the laughter, the shorthand inside jokes, the references to things that no one else would understand.

When they rejoined us in the kitchen, Elia slipped easily into the role of helper, pouring more wine and unbagging snacks. “This place is lovely,”

she said. It's very you, Daisy. Warm, organised, a little intimidatingly clean."

I shot Daisy a look, which she caught with an impish grin. "Thanks to Jordan. He's my domestic goddess, aren't you?"

That earned a low laugh from Spencer, who leaned on the counter. "Man, you make the rest of us look bad. Don't tell Elia you're ironing blouses and scrubbing bathrooms."

"Oh, she already knows how good he is," Daisy quipped, topping up Spencer's glass. "And how bad you are."

Spencer raised his brows with an amused grin and took a drink of the red wine. The familiarity between all of us felt grounding. "But all the ladies love a bad boy, right?"

It didn't take long for the first bottle to disappear. Daisy poured herself another generous glass and giggled, cheeks turning pink as the wine visibly loosened her. "What? It's Friday!" she told them when they smiled at her, enjoying the drink. "No lectures, no work, no emails from my supervisor until Monday at the earliest. Tonight I am strictly off-duty."

Spencer matched her drink for drink, his flirtatious energy crackling in easy banter. "I'll tell you, Daisy, my heart broke a little once you left. Jordan, how'd you ever get this beautiful woman? And why would you take her from me, to move out to the sticks with you?" He winked at Elia, who rolled her eyes in faux exasperation and sipped her water. She'd explained early that she was the designated driver for tonight, much to Daisy's disappointment.

"So, come on, I want all the local gossip," Elia said, tipping her gaze toward Daisy with a conspiratorial smile. "Anyone interesting or famous? Or is it just garden gnome feuds and curtain twitchers?"

Daisy laughed, swirling her glass. "No. They're all really nice. There's even a neighbourhood watch group. It's quite a close-knit community."

“I bet it is,” Spencer laughed, sharing a meaningful look with Elia, who giggled and looked down into her glass of water.

“What?” I frowned at them both.

“Nothing,” Elia said, though her cheeks turned pink.

“Tell them,” Spencer sighed, waving a hand in the direction of me and Daisy. “They need to know. They’re almost neighbours.”

“You tell them.” Elia’s face was bright red now.

Spencer rolled his eyes and turned to look at us square-on. “We know a couple... I think they live at the end of the street. Corinne and Paul. Have you met them yet?”

“Sure,” I nodded, though I didn’t tell them the story of how we’d met, the day of Kendall’s accident. “We’ve spoken a couple of times.”

“Well, I guess you should know that we...” he glanced at Elia, who nodded for him to continue, “We had a thing... Years ago now. The four of us. I used to work with Paul.”

I stared at them. “What do you mean?”

“You mean, like... swingers?” Daisy breathed.

“No,” Elia laughed, the sound light like tiny bells chiming. “I dated Paul, and Spencer dated Corinne. Right before we got together.”

“It was only a brief thing,” Spencer explained. “That’s how Elia and I met, through them. It was one of those weird serendipitous things where I ended up with Corinne’s friend—” he pointed at Elia.

“—And I ended up with Paul’s friend,” Elia continued, indicating at Spencer. “And then we got Corinne and Paul together after that. It all worked out beautifully.”

“Right,” I nodded, trying to take in this new information. “Got it. Are you still in touch with them?”

“Occasionally,” Elia nodded. “Although we didn’t know you lived on the same cul-de-sac until you gave us the address. We’ve never been to their house, although they’ve invited us a couple of times.”

A puzzle was starting to form in my head, although I couldn’t put the pieces together yet. Kendall’s curious questions about our friends this afternoon. Her electrician friend going off with them. Spencer and Elia’s amusement at Daisy’s description of Far Bridge Rise as a close-knit community.

“Anyway, we’re glad you’ve come to visit us,” Daisy said, pulling me from my thoughts. “Let’s not talk about your exes. You’re here to talk about us!”

“True,” Spencer grinned, clinking his glass to my wife’s. “Fuck Corinne and Paul. Let’s celebrate you guys and your new place.”

We continued chatting after Elia and Daisy paired up in the kitchen to cook dinner, while Spencer and I talked, this time about sports and politics rather than our mutual acquaintances from down the street. Later, we ate, and the food was terrific, as Elia had promised. Once the plates were empty, we settled back on the sofas with full bellies and more drinks.

I wanted to do a little probing about Corinne and Paul, but as if she could read my mind, Daisy, now flushed and giggling from the wine, shook her head as soon as I said ‘So... about—’

Instead, she rummaged in a drawer and triumphantly produced a deck of cards. “Shall we play something?” She caught a look from Spencer and shook her head. “Strip poker’s a no-go, but maybe Gin Rummy?”

We played cards for a while, and, as always, Spencer seemed to have all the luck. The room was getting a little warm as we put the cards to one side, and he made a show of slowly peeling off his top, revealing a T-shirt so tight it showed off every contour of his chest. He’d been working out, that much was clear. He saw Daisy look and flexed an impressive bicep. My

wife replied with a howl of mock outrage, throwing a throw pillow at him. “Show-off!”

That led to a playful pillow fight between the four of us, until a can of beer got knocked over, causing Elia to apologise profusely. Daisy told her not to worry as I grabbed a mop from the storage cupboard and cleared up. The hardwood floor wiped up easily, and Daisy grabbed a cloth, drying the floor behind me so none of us could slip in our drunken state. Once she’d finished, she stripped off her own top, leaning back into the couch in her white ribbed vest. It had ridden up her belly slightly, showing an inviting flash of tanned skin above the waistband of her jeans. Her blonde hair had come undone, falling in loose waves around her shoulders, a flush lingering high on her cheeks.

“Oof, I’m done,” she groaned, stretching theatrically. “That’s all my exercise done for the week!” Her vest hugged her closely, showing a teasing glimpse of her bra and the soft lines of her breasts underneath. I caught Spencer glancing over, interest in his eyes.

“I thought we weren’t playing strip poker,” he said easily in the way old friends did, teasing each other. “But I’m game if you are.”

He went to lift the T-shirt, giving Daisy and me a flash of his washboard abs, but Elia stopped him with a gentle arm on his hand. “Calm down,” she giggled. “I think you’re getting overexcited again, Spencer.”

“And you know you’ll lose anyway,” Daisy raised her eyebrows. “Your luck has to run out sometime.”

“I never lose,” he promised, giving me a wink to reassure me he was only playing around.

When the time finally came for them to leave, Elia hugged Daisy tight, promising to meet up again before too long, and Spencer gave me a manly and slightly drunken hug, squeezing me hard enough to almost break a rib.

“I’m glad you two are doing well,” he murmured, low into my ear. “Look after her. We need to sort out a night out, me and you. Just us guys.”

“We’ll plan something,” I promised.

As their car headlights disappeared up the road, the house seemed suddenly quiet. Daisy, still tipsy, stumbled back to the living room and flopped onto the sofa, one arm flung over her head, the other tugging her vest up just enough to show a sliver of her taut stomach again.

She beckoned me closer with a crooked finger. “Come here.” Her voice was low, almost a growl. “I am drunk, and you have no idea how much I want you right now.” With surprising determination, she sat up, tugging her vest over her head and letting it fall behind her, then unfastening her jeans.

“Daisy. I keep telling you to be aware when the curtains are open. We have a neighbourhood watch on the cul-de-sac,” I warned, but I was only half-serious. The other half was aware of how the thought of someone seeing her naked sent a tingle down my spine, and it came out as a teasing tone in my voice.

She laughed brazenly, giddy, seemingly unbothered by the possibility of an audience. “Maybe I want someone to watch.” She kicked off her jeans, leaving her in her pink bra and panties.

Her words made my pulse race as I joined her on the sofa, an illicit thrill mingling with urgency as she wrapped her arms around my neck, pulling me into a hungry kiss. Her lips were warm, her breath sweet and reckless, tasting of wine and riskiness. I fumbled up her thighs, feeling the heat of her skin beneath my hands and the tight shiver of her anticipation, but when I reached the waistband of her panties. I stopped. As tempting as it might be, as drunk as she was, I wasn’t going to do something crazy like fuck where anyone could see us.

“Come on,” I whispered, scooping her up into my arms, even as she reached behind her back and uncoupled her bra. I carried her giggling to the staircase, stealing a glance over my shoulder at the windows, but it was too dark outside to see if anyone was on patrol.

Upstairs, I set Daisy down in the bedroom, and she tumbled onto the bed, tossing aside her unclasped bra and then sliding down her panties, gazing at

me, wild and wanting. I stripped, barely pausing before joining her, my hands hungrily exploring her skin again, our kisses deep and desperate. She arched beneath me, her hands pulling at my hair, her pussy slick and ready as I slid two fingers into her wet hole. Then I got between her legs, her thighs riding around my hips, pointed my already-hard cock at her and entered her in one thrust, before stopping.

“What’s wrong?” she asked, her voice husky and impatient. “Do it. I want you now.”

“Just let me close the curtains,” I said, sliding from the bed and walking to the window. It had been in my mind to leave them open, but I just couldn’t, as exciting as the thought might be. There was too much at stake. We didn’t know our neighbours, and while Kendall might be comfortable having sex with the lights on and the windows uncovered, I wasn’t.

As I drew the curtain across, I glanced through the glass into the night. The porch light from across the street flickered on — a silhouette framed for a moment in the reflection. Linda Petrosky, raincoat cinched and torch in hand, patrolled solemnly beneath the streetlamps. She paused, peering with silent curiosity toward our window, her angular face briefly illuminated. Our eyes met, but she didn’t look away, didn’t hurry, but stared at me with a strange patience.

I stepped back, a chill running down my spine for some reason.

“What’s wrong?” Daisy asked from the bed.

“Nothing.” I pulled the curtains shut, not prepared to let Kendall’s mother ruin the night. I got back on the bed, once again between Daisy’s thighs, entering her easily and began to fuck her hard, pushing any thoughts of the Petrovsky family from my thoughts.

However, midway through the sex, Daisy’s voice rasped against my collarbone, thick with wine and horniness. “You know,” she murmured, pulling back just enough to look into my eyes with an amused, hazy grin, “Did you see Spencer tonight? He’s... definitely been... going to the

gym... his body. So toned, so strong..." She was out of breath from the sex and paused between every few words. "Elia's so lucky."

"And yet, Corinne still let him go," I replied, reminding her of the surprising coincidence we'd learned about earlier.

"I didn't... expect that," Daisy replied, kissing my neck. "Elia's totally different from Corinne too. She's such a tiny little thing... smart, sassy, sexy. Whereas Corinne is quite... I don't know. Just different."

I was sliding my cock in and out of Daisy slowly while she talked, enjoying the feeling of her tightness around me.

"And... they've been together ages... right? Nearly a decade. So Corinne was a long time ago. And still... Elia and Spencer are so... obviously in love. It's inspiring. Makes me want to find us... something like that... in ten years." She laughed softly, knowing her words were coming out in a horny, amused jumble. "Don't you think?"

I didn't know what her point was entirely, but for some reason, heat pooled low in my belly, the memory of Spencer's eyes on Daisy's body mingling with the feel of her fingertips drawing shapes across my chest as I continued to slowly fuck her. "Hey, we're doing alright. We're in love. And our sex life is as good as ever," I said, voice low, hoping my smile masked the conflicting swirl of excitement — and jealousy — that stirred in my gut for some reason.

Her fingers dug in playfully. "God, Spencer... he's got a big dick too, hasn't he? You can just tell." Her eyes sparkled mischievously in the darkness. "I mean, Elia looks so damn happy... I can't blame her."

I swallowed hard, heart racing. The candour of Daisy's drunken tease caught me off guard. She pressed a kiss to my jaw, pulling me closer. "I wonder if they fucked, Corinne and Spencer? And Paul and Elia?"

"I don't know," I laughed at her continued rambling.

“I bet you fancy Elia, too,” Daisy giggled, the suggestion coming from nowhere. Then, a pause, a tipsy laugh, followed by, “Not that I fancy Spencer, of course. You know I’m all yours, Mr Modern Husband. I’m just drunk.” But the truth lingered in her gaze longer than the joke, unspoken and raw. It wasn’t hard to figure out that she was excited from seeing Spencer’s gym body.

The realisation gave me another sharp pang of jealousy, but I pushed it down and cupped her cheek, brushing hair from her damp forehead. “And I’m all yours,” I whispered, then shoved my cock inside her roughly, making her moan. She finally stopped talking about our friends and neighbours, her hands tangling in my hair, pulling me deeper as she gasped and pressed her pussy forward onto me.

I thrust deeper, harder, feeling her walls clamp around me with every stroke. Her nails raked down my back. “Faster,” She cried out, snaking her fingers between our bodies, finding her clit and teasing herself as I took her. “Fuck me hard, Jordan.”

Even though I was in a rhythm now, in the full flow of sex, my mind wandered again. I couldn’t help but wonder if she’d always fancied Spencer, or if his new gym body had made her suddenly notice him. Daisy was right. I did fancy Elia. It was impossible not to. She was such a beautiful, petite girl, and with her sharp wit and stunning figure, I’d always found her sexy. But I was all-in on Daisy. I always had been, always would be. The fact that Kendall had captured my imagination meant nothing. I was happily married, just like Spencer and Elia.

But for some reason, it wasn’t Elia’s slim body that floated behind my eyelids right at that moment. It was Kendall. I rammed hard into Daisy, and she came, her body shuddering beneath me, her fingers pressing against her clit for a moment before pulling away, and the feeling made me cum too. I stayed inside her, emptying my seed deep into her pussy, but it wasn’t Daisy I was imagining filling up.

And as I slid to the bed beside her, utterly exhausted, I caught a glimpse of Daisy staring at the ceiling with a hazy, contented expression on her face.

And I had the strangest feeling that she hadn't been imagining me either.

Psychology of Relationships - Personal Notes

My head is pounding this morning, and I can barely remember anything from last night after Spencer stripped his shirt off. I know we had sex, Jordan and I, because I woke up naked and satisfied, but the details are completely fuzzy. Too much wine. I need to be more careful about that, especially when we have guests over. Jordan seemed in a good mood this morning though, so whatever happened must have been alright.

I keep thinking about Spencer and Elia. There's something about them that I can't quite put my finger on, but it's been nagging at me for years now. They're so comfortable together, so secure in their relationship in a way that goes beyond just being happy. It's like they've figured out something the rest of us haven't. I've watched them at parties before we moved, and Spencer will openly flirt with other women right in front of Elia, and she just laughs about it, sometimes even joins in the conversation. And Elia is so touchy with other men in a way that would make me jealous if Jordan did that with other women, but Spencer doesn't seem bothered at all.

I've had suspicions about them for years now, wondering if they've experimented with swinging or an open relationship or something like that. Tonight, when Spencer was showing off his body and making jokes about strip poker, Elia wasn't threatened or embarrassed. She was amused. And when they told us about dating Corinne and Paul before they got together, it wasn't awkward or defensive the way people usually are when they talk about exes. They were almost nostalgic about it, like it was a fond memory they all shared rather than something to be jealous about. The way they met through swapping partners seems so coincidental unless it wasn't coincidental at all. Maybe they were part of some kind of group back then?

I keep thinking about that night three years ago at Jake's birthday party when Spencer and I ended up alone in the kitchen after everyone else had passed out. We were both so drunk, and I was upset about the fight Jordan and I had earlier, and Spencer was being so sweet and understanding. One minute we were just talking, and the next we were kissing and his hands were under my shirt, and I wanted him so badly it scared me. If Elia hadn't woken up and called out for him, we probably would have done something we couldn't take back. We made a pact the next morning, hungover and horrified, to never speak of it again and pretend it never happened.

But I'm not my mother. I will never be like her. I saw what her constant affairs did to our family, how her cheating destroyed my parents' marriage and tore us all apart. I have to constantly remind myself that's part of why I chose to study relationship psychology in the first place — to understand what makes marriages work and what destroys them, so that I can help other couples as a counsellor someday. I need complete trust and fidelity in my own relationship, even if I can admire how Spencer and Elia seem comfortable with their approach, whatever it is.

Jordan and Elia can never know how close Spencer and I came to ruining everything because I refuse to become the kind of woman who destroys marriages like my mother did. What almost happened that night was a mistake, a moment of weakness when I was drunk and angry.

But I've never forgotten how he felt against me or how much we wanted each other, and last night, there was a moment when he was looking at me that made me wonder if he really did manage to forget — like we promised we would — or if he still sometimes thinks about it too.

Chapter eight

Chapter 8: A New Project

Saturday morning hit me like a freight train. I sat at our kitchen table nursing the kind of hangover that made me question all my life choices from the night before, watching Daisy push around the breakfast I'd made her with obvious distaste.

"I'm sorry," she mumbled, barely looking at the bacon and eggs I'd prepared. "I know you went to all this trouble, but I just can't face it right now."

"Too much wine last night?" I asked, though the answer was obvious from her pale complexion and the careful way she held her head.

"Way too much." She pressed her palms against her temples, her fingers tangling in her blonde hair. "I should know better than to match Spencer drink for drink. That man has hollow legs."

"Hmm, I don't know," I commented, tucking into my own breakfast. "He was pretty drunk by the time he left, too."

Despite her obvious discomfort, she managed a smile, reminding me for some reason of how passionate she'd been the night before — how she'd talked about Spencer's body, how intense our lovemaking had become. The memory sent a warm pulse through me even as I watched her struggle with her hangover.

Despite feeling dreadful, she'd spread her university notes across the table, determined to salvage something productive from today. Her handwriting looked shakier than usual as she tried to focus, her pen moving across the page in what looked like stream-of-consciousness rambling rather than academic work.

I glanced up at her from my bacon just in time to see her rip a page from her notebook with sudden violence, crumpling it into a tight ball before

tossing it toward the bin. The paper bounced off the rim and rolled across the floor.

"Why'd you do that?" I asked.

She shrugged without looking up. "Nothing important. Just getting my thoughts out on the page." Her tone was dismissive, final, making it clear she wasn't interested in elaborating.

My phone buzzed with an email notification, breaking the moment. Finally — Sarah! Was she getting back to me about potential work? I hoped so. I'd been waiting for this response all week.

"What is it?" Daisy's brown eyes peered at me over the kitchen table.

"The commissioning editor I did some work for this week," I said, unable to hide my excitement as I read the content of the email. "She wants to meet this afternoon. She liked the piece I did and has a new commission for me."

Daisy looked up from her notes, her face brightening through her hangover. "That's wonderful! Where are you meeting?"

"She suggested a restaurant in town. Says she was in the area anyway." I scanned the email again, surprised but pleased by the unexpected face-to-face meeting. "This is actually the first time we'll meet in person. Everything's been emails and phone calls up until now."

"Even better. A proper business lunch." She smiled warmly at me. "I'm so happy for you. You deserve this break."

The genuine pleasure in Daisy's voice reminded me of why I'd fallen in love with her. Even hungover and struggling, she would also still put me and my feelings first.

"I should probably get ready if I'm going to make it," I said, standing and gathering my phone. "Will you be alright here on your own?"

"Of course. I've got plenty of work to keep me busy." She gestured at her scattered notes. "And maybe a long shower to help with this headache."

Upstairs, I pulled a clean shirt from the wardrobe, taking my time to choose something that struck the right balance between professional and approachable. My hands trembled slightly as I worked the buttons, a combination of hangover nerves and genuine excitement about finally meeting Sarah face-to-face after months of email exchanges.

The bathroom mirror reflected back a man who looked more optimistic than he had in weeks. I splashed aftershave onto my jaw, wincing slightly at the sting, and ran my fingers through my hair until it looked presentable.

"What time will you be back?" Daisy called from downstairs, her voice carrying that particular hollow echo that meant she was still sitting at the kitchen table.

"Probably around five or six," I called back, adjusting my collar one final time. "It depends on how long the meeting runs. First time meeting her in person, so who knows."

"Take your time. Buy her a drink and pay for her meal. Butter her up. This could be the break you've been waiting for."

When I came back downstairs, Daisy was exactly where I'd left her — hunched over her notebook, a fresh cup of coffee steaming beside her elbow. The crumpled paper remained on the floor where it had rolled, but as I went to pick it up, she quickly got up and grabbed it herself, tossing it into the bin.

"Go!" she told me. "I'll tidy up. Put your best foot forward and try to enjoy the meeting."

I wondered why she'd been so eager for me not to pick up the note, but shrugged and grabbed my portfolio bag from the hall cupboard, checking that all my best samples were still appropriately organised inside.

"You sure you'll be alright?" I asked, pausing beside her chair as she sat back down.

She looked up, pencil still poised over a fresh page covered in her neat handwriting. "Stop fussing. I'm twenty-five, not five." But her smile was warm, affectionate, the kind that reminded me why I'd fallen in love with her. "Besides, I have plenty to keep me busy."

Her phone buzzed then, the screen lighting up beside her coffee mug. She glanced at it, and I caught a flicker of something — mild irritation, maybe? — cross her face before she turned the phone face down without reading the message.

"Work stuff?" I asked, genuinely curious rather than suspicious.

"Actually, no." She tucked a strand of blonde hair behind her ear, a gesture I'd learned meant she was choosing her words carefully. "It's my supervisor from university. She wants to discuss my research proposal on Monday. Something about expanding the scope of my project."

"That's good, right? Expanding usually means more funding."

"Mmm." Daisy's pen tapped against the paper in a rhythm I recognised — the same one she used when she was working through a complex problem. "Maybe. I just need to get this essay planned and started. I'll worry about Monday later."

I leaned down to kiss her forehead, catching the familiar scent of her shampoo mixed with last night's perfume still lingering on her skin. The combination sent a warm pulse through me, a brief flashback to how dirty she'd been in bed, how she'd talked about Spencer's dick likely being big.

"Okay, I'll go," I murmured against her hair. "Text me if you need anything, alright?"

"I will. Now go impress Sarah with your artistic brilliance."

The drive into town gave me time to settle my nerves and think about the commission possibilities. Sarah's email had been typically brief, just a request to meet and discuss a new project with specific requirements. After

months of generic fantasy artwork and gaming illustrations, the prospect of something different had my creative mind spinning with possibilities.

The restaurant she'd suggested was tucked away on a side street I'd driven past hundreds of times but never really noticed. Small and intimate, with dark wooden tables and soft lighting that seemed designed for private conversations rather than casual dining. The kind of place where business deals were made over expensive wine.

I spotted her immediately, though she wasn't what I'd expected. Somehow, I'd pictured Sarah as a middle-aged English woman with greying hair and sensible shoes. The name had conjured up images of tweedy academia and publishing house stuffiness. Instead, the woman who stood to greet me was clearly of Asian descent, possibly Thai, with the kind of timeless beauty that made it impossible to guess her exact age. She could have been thirty-five or fifty. Her smooth skin and elegant bone structure gave nothing away.

Her dark hair was pulled back in a severe bun that emphasised the graceful line of her neck, and she wore a charcoal business suit that looked like it had cost more than I made in a month. Everything about her screamed success, from her perfectly manicured nails to the confidence in her posture.

"Jordan?" She extended a hand as I approached, her voice carrying just the faintest trace of an accent I couldn't quite place. "Sarah Suwannathat. Thank you for meeting on such short notice."

Sarah's handshake was smooth but businesslike, her face breaking into an unexpectedly warm smile as she gestured for me to sit. "It's good to finally meet you in person, Jordan. I've been looking forward to this. Phone calls and emails aren't quite the same as sitting down face to face."

I sank into the dark wooden chair opposite her, grateful for the subdued light and its forgiving shadow to cover up any traces of my hangover. "It's nice to meet you, too. I'm glad you suggested it. Sometimes it helps to see who you're working with. Put a face to the name, that sort of thing."

She laughed, low and musical, her accent smooth with just a ghost of something Southeast Asian. "My aunt Kamol owns the restaurant, it's been

in the family since I was a girl. I come here every time I'm in town, and when I saw that you didn't live far away, I thought it'd be good. So, you're getting the family treatment today."

As if on cue, a petite woman in a neat black apron appeared at the table, greeting Sarah with a flurry of affectionate Thai before turning to me. "Welcome. Please, you relax here." Her smile was gentle, her dark eyes lively as she poured two glasses of a pale, almost greenish wine.

"Don't let her insist you try the green curry until after the meeting," Sarah murmured as her aunt retreated, her tone conspiratorial.

I grinned. "I'll remember that."

We chatted for a few minutes, sharing small talk about the weather and the quirks of working from home. Sarah spoke about childhood summers spent at these tables, helping out in the kitchen, listening to her aunt talk about how every meal should be an invitation. Her stories made the place feel unfamiliar and cosy all at once.

"So," she said, finally sliding a neat, branded folder onto the table between us. "Let's look at the new project. I'm managing artwork for a sci-fi RPG launching early next year." She opened the folder to reveal concept sheets — three characters, sketched in bold, gestural strokes. "The client wants them to stand out as a set. Two women, one man, all confident, athletic, fine-boned, but distinct."

I leaned over the sketches, taking in the details. Long limbs, elegant posture, minimal clothing, each character exuding strength as much as beauty. "These are great. I can definitely work with this. Is there a particular style or setting I should keep in mind?"

Sarah nodded, tapping a parchment-colored sheet. "Dark urban fantasy mixed with futuristic sci-fi. I'll email you the full plan. There's a lot of tension between magic, the future and our more mundane world, so if you can show something of that, that would be perfect." She paused, smiling mischievously at me. "Oh, and make them hot. Like... very hot."

“Sexy but not pornographic?” I joked.

Her eyes crinkled with agreement. “Always dancing that line in modern sci-fi. The client is clear about what they want. The game is designed for adults, but they want their characters to have life, not mere pinups.”

“Gotcha.”

Sarah set down her wine glass and tilted her head, watching me study one of the sketches with a critical eye. “But to answer your question, yes. The anatomy will be important here. These characters need to feel real, not just idealised. Do you work from live models, or do you rely on photo reference?”

The question caught me slightly off guard. “Honestly? I’ve mostly worked from photo references or simply from memory. I’ve never had the budget for professional models, although I have drawn a few figure studies in my time, of course.”

“Mmm.” She made a note in the margin of her folder. “It might be worth considering for this project. There’s something about working from life, the way light falls on the human body, the subtle tensions in posture, that’s hard to capture from static photos. Especially when you’re trying to convey intimacy between characters. These three characters are involved romantically in the game.”

“I see. I suppose that’s true.” I remembered Kendall’s offer. Was it fate? “I’ll see what I can do.”

We wrapped up the meeting with handshakes and promises of preliminary art within a week. The woman who’d brought out our food, Aunt Kamol, emerged from the kitchen to press a takeaway container of pad thai into my hands. “For your wife, she must try,” and refused any attempt at payment.

I pulled into our driveway just before five, the autumn sun already beginning its descent toward the horizon. The house looked peaceful, with warm light glowing from the kitchen windows. I grabbed the takeaway container and my portfolio bag, juggling both as I fumbled for my keys.

"Daisy?" I called out as I pushed through the front door. "I'm back. And I come bearing gifts from Sarah's aunt."

The house felt unusually quiet. No music playing, no sound of her moving around upstairs. I set the food and my bag on the kitchen counter, noticing her abandoned coffee cup and notebook still on the table, though she'd clearly tidied up. The crumpled paper was gone from the floor, the breakfast dishes washed and put away.

"Daisy?" I called again, louder this time.

"Up here!" Her voice drifted down from upstairs, slightly muffled. "Just getting out of the shower. How did it go?"

I climbed the stairs two at a time, finding our bedroom door ajar. Steam drifted from the bathroom, carrying the familiar scent of her coconut body wash. She emerged wrapped in a towel, her blonde hair damp and darkened, skin flushed pink from the hot water.

"It went brilliantly," I said, unable to keep the excitement from my voice. "Sarah's working on this science fiction game. There are three main characters, all drawn to really specific physical requirements. It's exactly the kind of challenging work I've been hoping for."

Daisy's face lit up with genuine pleasure. "That's awesome! I told you this might be the break you've been waiting for." She crossed to the wardrobe, selecting clothes with casual, unselfconscious ease. "When does she need the work by?"

"Preliminary art in a week." I watched as she dropped the towel, flashing me her pert breasts and curvy ass, then pulled on underwear — lacy white panties and a matching bra, nothing fancy, but something about the domestic intimacy of the moment made my pulse quicken. "She asked if I work from live models."

"Did you tell her you draw from memory?" Daisy pulled a soft grey sweater over her head, her voice muffled by fabric.

"Yes, and from photo references." I leaned against the doorframe. "But she made a good point about capturing real anatomy and lighting. Made me think about something, actually."

"What?"

"I forgot to mention this to you, but Kendall stopped me on the street. We got talking about my art and..." It felt weird telling her this, but I'd realised that if I didn't — and Kendall did — Daisy might think I'd kept it from her for a reason.

Daisy paused, one leg half into her jeans. "Kendall offered to model for you?" she guessed.

"Yesterday, when I ran into her coming back from the art shop. She said she's done it before." I watched her face carefully, trying to gauge her reaction. "It was just neighbourly chat at the time, but now I'm wondering if I should take her up on it."

Daisy finished pulling on her jeans, her expression thoughtful rather than defensive. "Why do you need Kendall? I could model for you."

The words hung in the air between us, unexpected and charged with something I couldn't quite identify.

"You?" I tried to keep my voice neutral, though my mind immediately conjured images of Daisy posed in the kind of minimal clothing Sarah's sketches had shown.

She crossed her arms, but there was a flush in her cheeks that hadn't been there a moment ago. "Why not? I've got the body type, haven't I? Slim, athletic. And you already know what I look like naked, so there'd be no awkwardness."

"I mean, of course you do, but—"

"But what?" She cut me off, her tone sharper than I expected. "You'd rather have our neighbour strip down in your studio than your own wife?"

"That's not what I'm saying." I held up my hands defensively. "And I never said anything about stripping. I just didn't think you'd be interested in that kind of thing. You've never mentioned wanting to model before."

Daisy turned to the mirror, running a brush through her damp hair with deliberate strokes. In the reflection, I could see her expression, a complex mix of defiance and something else. Excitement, maybe? "I'm not against the idea. If you kept it completely professional, of course. It's much more appropriate than having a young stranger parade around our house naked."

There was an edge to her voice that made me wonder what she wasn't saying. Was this about Kendall specifically? About not wanting me alone with our attractive young neighbour? Or was there something more to it?

"You're right. It might even be fun," I conceded. "As long as you don't mind your body being shown to thousands of people playing the game."

"They won't know it's the artist's wife. I could be anybody."

I couldn't help but smile at that. "Fair point."

"So we're agreed then?" She moved closer, reaching up to touch my cheek in that wifely gesture that always made me feel cared for. "You need models, I'll model. We can work out the details later, when you're ready to start the actual sketching or whatever it is that you do first."

"Agreed." I pulled her close, kissing her forehead. "Though for the record, I wasn't planning on having Kendall parade around naked. It was just an idle thought."

"Mmm." Daisy's arms slipped around my waist. "Keep it that way. Now, did you say something about food from Sarah's aunt?"

As we headed back downstairs, I found myself wondering if the idea excited her more than she was willing to admit. And part of me, the part that got turned on by the thought of sharing her, was excited by that possibility in ways I didn't fully understand.

That was a complication for another day. Right now, we had pad thai to eat and a Saturday evening stretching ahead of us. But we'd barely started dividing the pad thai onto plates when a knock came at the front door.

"I'll get it," I said, setting down my fork and heading through to the hallway.

Through the frosted glass panel beside the door, I could make out a familiar silhouette. I pulled the door open to find Morgan standing there, wrapped in her navy quilted jacket against the cooling evening air. Her curly, dark hair was pulled back in a practical ponytail.

"Jordan, hi!" Her smile was warm, genuine. "I'm sorry to drop by unannounced. I hope I'm not interrupting dinner?"

Little did I know that this unexpected visit would change everything.

Project Specification Sheet

Untitled Science-Fiction RPG Client: Elysium Designs Digital / Contact: Sarah Suwannathat

Style: Dark urban fantasy mixed with science fiction, realistic proportions, mature audience

CHARACTER CONCEPT ART NEEDED:

NOVA (Female Primary) Nova should appear to be twenty-five to twenty-eight years old, with an athletic dancer's physique, standing at five feet seven inches tall. Her most striking feature is her shoulder-length, silver-white hair, interwoven with subtle tech implants that catch the light. She wears a form-fitting tactical bodysuit with strategic mesh panels that reveal glimpses of her bioluminescent tattoos, which run along her spine and arms. As a cyber-enhanced infiltrator, Nova

moves with fluid grace and carries herself with quiet confidence. She is curvy and sexy as the primary love interest in the early game.

ZARA (Female Support)Zara presents as twenty-two to twenty-five years old, with a petite yet powerful acrobat's build, standing at five feet four inches. Her deep burgundy hair falls in an asymmetrical cut that frames her face dramatically. She favours minimal armour pieces worn over a revealing base layer that shows off her mechanical arm enhancement. Zara's confident posture and knowing smile suggest she's comfortable with polyamorous relationship dynamics. As the team's tech specialist, she's brilliant but playful, often challenging traditional romantic boundaries. She is very scantily clad, enticing the player to romance her alongside Nova.

DRAKE (Male Lead)Drake appears to be twenty-eight to thirty-two years old, with a lean, muscular fighter's build, standing at six feet one inch. His dark brown hair maintains a slightly unkempt appearance that adds to his roguish charm. He wears a long coat over fitted combat gear that emphasises his broad shoulders and narrow waist. Facial scars tell stories of past battles, but his charismatic expression draws people in rather than intimidating them. As the player character, Drake possesses the romantic agency to pursue storylines with Nova exclusively, Zara exclusively, or maintain intimate relationships with both women simultaneously.

Handwritten note in blue pen at bottom:

Jordan, I really enjoyed having dinner today. It was lovely to meet in person finally, and I'd absolutely love to do it again soon, perhaps somewhere of your choosing? We could discuss the finer details of the project over wine, possibly, once you've sent me the preliminary designs. I loved your last work, and I have a feeling that you and I are going to work very well together.

Sarah XOXO

Chapter nine

Chapter 9: The First Step

"Not at all. We were just starting. Come in." I stepped aside, letting Morgan into the warmth of our hallway.

Daisy appeared from the kitchen, still holding her plate. "Morgan! Is everything alright?"

"Everything's fine, don't worry." Morgan's hands were tucked into her jacket pockets, her posture relaxed in that effortless way she had. "I just wanted to follow up on what we mentioned the other day, about you joining the neighbourhood watch rotation. No pressure at all, but I thought I'd check if tonight still works for you both? Only if you're free, of course."

She glanced between us, her expression friendly but not pushy. There was something reassuringly maternal about Morgan's manner, always asking rather than demanding, organising rather than commanding.

"You did mention starting this weekend," Daisy said, gesturing Morgan toward the living room. "Although I admit it had slipped my mind. Why don't you come through to the kitchen? Can I get you anything? Tea? Coffee?"

"Oh no, I won't stay long. I know it's Saturday evening, and you look like you're settled in for the night." Morgan leaned against the counter, unzipping her jacket but not removing it, her body language indicating that she intended to keep this brief. "It's just that Frank had to pull out of tonight's rotation, and we like to keep at least two people on duty. One or two for patrol, one for observation."

"What does that actually involve?" I asked, settling into the armchair across from her. "The watching part, I mean. I did a patrol with Tyler the other night."

"That's usually done from home, actually. We provide binoculars and a little notebook. You'd just keep watch from an upstairs window and note down

any unusual activity. Times, descriptions, that kind of thing." Morgan smiled apologetically. "I know it sounds terribly nosy, but it's really just about community safety. Making sure everyone feels secure."

"How long would we need to do it for?" I asked.

"Usually about two hours, but if you can't manage that, just as long as you can. You can split it however works best, both of you together, or one does patrol while the other observes." She pulled a small notebook from her jacket pocket, checking something. "Tonight would be eight until ten, if you're available. But truly, if you've got other plans, there's no obligation. We can always ask someone else."

Daisy and I exchanged glances. The pad thai could wait, and we didn't have anything pressing planned for the evening. After last night with Spencer and Elia, a quiet evening doing something productive for the locals actually sounded appealing.

"I think we could do that," Daisy said slowly. "What do you think, Jordan?"

"I think we could do that," I said, nodding. "Sounds straightforward enough."

"Wonderful!" Morgan's face lit up with genuine pleasure. "I have the supplies in my car. Let me just grab them."

She disappeared back through our front door, returning moments later with a canvas messenger bag slung over her shoulder. From it, she produced a pair of compact binoculars in a padded case and two small notebooks with spiral bindings.

"Nothing too fancy," she said, setting them on our coffee table. "The binoculars are decent quality, better than what most people have lying around at home. And the notebooks have some basic guidelines in the front about what to look for and how to record it."

I picked up one of the notebooks and flipped through the first few pages. Someone had typed up simple instructions: times to note, descriptions to

record, what constituted ‘suspicious activity’ versus everyday community life.

"Vehicle registrations, if you can see them," Morgan explained, pointing to a section in the notebook. "Description of people who don't seem to belong, though obviously use common sense. We're not trying to create a police state here."

Daisy lifted the binoculars, testing their weight. "These are quite good quality."

"Linda insisted on getting proper equipment. She said if we're going to do this, we might as well do it properly." Morgan smiled fondly. "She takes the whole thing very seriously."

"So who else participates?" I asked. "Just out of curiosity."

"Oh, most of the street at one time or another," Morgan reeled off the names of everyone we'd met at the meeting, ticking them off on her fingers as she went along. "The Hendersons used to do it regularly until they left, so some new blood will help tremendously."

"Okay," Daisy nodded, glancing at me. "We'll give it a go. Is there anything we need to know? Any trouble expected? We've heard about these kids messing around..."

"Not really," Morgan shrugged. "The kids can be a menace, though. Paul said he saw a couple of young boys with fireworks hanging around the path at the far end, near the Petrovskys' house, but they moved on. Even so, perhaps keep an eye out."

"I'll check it out and let you know," I nodded, secretly relishing the opportunity to patrol the path behind Kendall's house again.

"Right then," Morgan said, zipping up her bag. "You're all set. Jordan, if you want to start with the patrol around eight, Daisy can take the first observation shift from upstairs. Or vice versa, whatever works for you. The

main thing is to note anything unusual, but don't worry too much about it. Most nights nothing happens at all."

"What if something does happen?" Daisy asked, shoving a lock of blonde hair behind her ear. "Something that needs reporting?"

"Use your judgment. If it's clearly a crime, such as break-ins, vandalism, that sort of thing, call the police directly. For anything else, just make detailed notes and we'll review them at the next community meeting." Morgan headed toward the door, pausing for a moment, her eyes meeting mine. "Honestly, the main benefit is just having people aware and watching."

After she left, Daisy and I sat looking at our new responsibilities in the notebook open on the coffee table.

"Well," Daisy said, picking up the binoculars again. "This should be interesting. Do you think we'll see anything?"

"Not really." I opened the notebook, scanning the guidelines more carefully while pushing the thoughts of seeing Kendall and the electrician out of my mind. "Like Morgan said, it's more of a deterrent than anything."

By eight o'clock, the autumn evening had settled into proper darkness, the streetlights casting pools of amber light along the curved road of Far Bridge Rise. I stood at our front door, notebook tucked into my jacket pocket, feeling oddly excited about my first proper patrol.

"I'll start with the perimeter," I called up to Daisy, who had positioned herself at our bedroom window with the binoculars. "Work my way up the cul-de-sac and come back around the rear path."

"I've got a good view from here," she called back. "Have fun playing detective."

The street felt still. No traffic. No people. There was a little wind, but barely more than a gentle breeze, brown leaves scattered across the path. I walked slowly up toward the far end of the cul-de-sac, my pulse quickening slightly

as I approached number fourteen, the Petrosky house where Kendall lived with her brother Michael and her parents, Frank and Linda.

I was hoping to catch another glimpse of Kendall, perhaps undressing for bed with her curtains carelessly open. The memory of seeing her naked body the other day still sent a warm pulse through me. But as I drew closer to the house, I saw something that stopped me in my tracks.

Frank Petrosky stood outside his front door, but he wasn't alone. Charlotte, Russell's blonde wife from number eleven across the street, was with him. They were standing close together, closer than strangers should, and as I watched from the shadow of a parked car, Frank took her hand.

Not a friendly handshake. Not a casual gesture of friendly comfort. He took her hand intimately, possessively, the way a man takes his lover's hand.

My breath caught as they turned toward the front door. Frank produced his keys, and together they disappeared inside his house. His and Linda's house. It seemed such a weird gesture that I just stood there, frozen for a moment, my mind racing. What the hell had I just witnessed? Frank Petrosky, middle-aged family man, walking hand-in-hand with his neighbour's young wife into his own home while his family was... where? Were Linda and the kids out for the evening? Something just seemed... off.

The rear pathway suddenly seemed like the obvious choice. If Frank and Charlotte were doing what I thought they were doing... No, they couldn't be. Could they?

I made my way around to the back of the houses, my heart pounding with a mixture of curiosity and arousal at what I might see. Like last time, the path was darker here, away from the streetlights, but I resisted the temptation to use my torch and navigated carefully toward the back of number fourteen.

Sure enough, the living room windows were open to the cool night air, warm light spilling out onto the small patio. And what I saw inside made my mouth go dry.

Frank and Charlotte stood in the centre of the room, kissing with desperate hunger. Her hands were already working at his shirt buttons while his fingers tangled in her blonde hair. This wasn't their first time, they moved with the confidence of established lovers.

I knew I should leave. I knew this was wrong, voyeuristic, opportunistic. But I couldn't tear my eyes away as Charlotte began to undress. She was sexy as hell — tall, with curves that made my cock stiffen in my pants. When she stripped down to her black silk underwear, a contrast to the conservative blouse and skirt she'd been wearing when I first saw them. Her full breasts were barely contained by the delicate bra. Her legs were long and slim, her waist narrow, flaring out into perfect hips.

Frank's hands roamed over her body with obvious familiarity, and when she freed his cock from his trousers, I was surprised by what I saw. He wasn't huge, but he was impressively thick and veiny, already stiff with arousal as Charlotte bent over the back of the sofa, pulling her silk panties aside for him, and Frank positioned himself behind her.

The sight was mesmerising, her blonde hair falling forward as he entered her shaved pussy, the way her back arched, the slow, deliberate rhythm they found together. Frank's hands gripped her hips as he moved inside her, and I could see the tension in Charlotte's body, the way she pushed back against him, enjoying every moment.

My phone buzzed, nearly giving me a heart attack. Daisy's name flashed on the screen, but I couldn't answer it—not here, not while watching this. I ducked behind the privet hedge, hoping they hadn't seen the light of the screen and let it go to voicemail, but when I looked back at the window, the show was over. Frank and Charlotte were both totally naked now, but he switched off the light and then the two of them moved upstairs in the darkness, out of view.

A moment later, the bedroom light came on, but the curtains were shut, and so I reluctantly tore myself away. But as I was walking back along the rear pathway, my mind reeling and my hard cock aching in my shorts, I nearly collided with someone coming the other way in the darkness.

"Jordan!" Morgan's voice was warm, amused. "How's the patrol going?"

"Oh, hi, Morgan." I tried to sound casual despite my racing pulse. "Just checking the rear pathways. All quiet back here."

She stepped closer, and in the dim light from a distant streetlamp, I could see her knowing smile. Her hand touched my arm gently. "Relax," she said softly. "You look like you've seen a ghost."

"I'm fine, just—"

"Excited from watching Frank and Charlotte?" Her voice was matter-of-fact, almost kind. "You're a bit slow on the uptake, aren't you?"

My mouth went dry. "I don't know what you mean."

Morgan's laugh was gentle, not mocking. Her dark eyes considered me, not unkindly. "Walk with me."

I followed her back around the rear path onto the main part of the cul-de-sac. The street was empty, quiet.

"Morgan, I—"

"Jordan, I've been doing this for nearly thirty years," the attractive black woman interrupted me. "I can read the signs. You saw Kendall naked the other day, didn't you? Tyler set that up. And when you came around here tonight, you were probably hoping for the same thing, weren't you?"

I couldn't speak, couldn't deny it.

"Yes, Frank is fucking Russell's wife. Tyler's fucked her too," she continued conversationally. "They've both also fucked Linda. In fact, Kendall isn't Frank's daughter at all. She's Tyler's. We've been swapping partners since before we even moved to this street."

The revelation hit me like a physical blow. Kendall's darker skin tone compared to her parents suddenly made sense. "What?"

"Russell is with Linda right now at number eleven as we speak. It's Saturday night — our usual arrangement." She reached into her navy blue quilted jacket and pulled out a slim booklet, covered in a fake leather-type material. "Most of the people you met at the watch meeting are part of our little club. Your wife is absolutely gorgeous, by the way. You probably noticed how many of the men were looking at her. She certainly has her admirers on Far Bridge Rise."

I took the booklet with trembling hands as she offered it to me. The cover read: "The Husband's Guide To Wife Sharing, Part 1."

"What even is this?" I asked, unable to look up and meet her gaze. My cheeks were burning with shame at being caught. "Morgan, I think you've got me all wrong—"

"Look, I know this is a lot to take in," Morgan said gently. "If you're not interested at all, you can forget this conversation ever happened. If you're offended, don't tell Daisy. Stop coming to watch meetings, keep to yourselves, and everything goes back to normal. No one will be offended. It's happened before with other couples, and it'll happen again in the future, no doubt."

She paused, studying my face in the dim light.

"But if you are interested in having some fun with the wives of Far Bridge Rise... well, you're very welcome to join us."

I didn't know what to say. "What about Daisy?" I managed to ask, purely to break the awkward silence.

Morgan's smile was knowing, almost predatory. "Jordan, I'm getting a certain vibe from you. I think you're one of those men who would love to try this but knows his wife isn't into it. Am I right?"

Heat flooded my cheeks even more. I took a deep breath to steady myself. "Maybe."

"Would you love to see your wife have sex with someone else?" The question was direct, shocking in its intimacy.

I couldn't answer, but my expression must have given me away.

"Don't be embarrassed," Morgan said kindly. She reached up and tucked a wavy strand of dark hair behind her ear. The wind was getting up slightly, and I shivered in the cool air. "Leave Daisy to me," she continued. "I've turned conservative women into enthusiastic hotwives before. Charlotte started off exactly like your wife — morally opposed to everything we do. Now, almost every man on the street has fucked her. And Russell loves it."

My cock was hard, straining against my jeans at the images her words conjured.

"If you want some fun," Morgan continued, stopping at the T-junction of the cul-de-sac, "Do this: fuck your wife tonight, but leave your bedroom curtains open. Someone will be watching — not me, but someone. That will be our signal that you're interested, and we'll start working on Daisy."

She squeezed my arm once more, then continued walking towards home, waiting for me to follow alongside her. "I promise you, Jordan, if you let us help you, you'll have more fun than you've ever imagined."

Right then, my phone buzzed again in my pocket, Daisy's name flashing insistently on the screen. This time, I couldn't ignore it. I'd completely forgotten to call her back.

"Jordan? Where are you?" Her voice carried a note of concern. "I tried calling you earlier."

Morgan patted me on the arm as we reached number six, and I watched as she headed inside, then replied. "Sorry, I'm on my way back now," I said, trying to keep my voice steady despite everything Morgan had just revealed. The booklet felt heavy in my jacket pocket, like it was burning through the fabric. "I just finished the patrol route and am nearly home."

"I've been watching from up here, and it's been pretty quiet. I saw you talking to Morgan, though. Is everything alright?"

"Yeah, she was just checking how the patrol had gone," I said, grateful for the easy lie. "Making sure I'd walked the route properly."

"That's nice of her." Daisy's tone was completely unsuspecting, accepting. "Well, hurry back. I'm getting bored up here with these binoculars."

"I'm right here."

I walked back toward our house, my mind spinning with everything Morgan had told me. The neighbourhood I thought I knew — quiet, respectable, family-oriented — was apparently something entirely different. A decades-long wife-sharing arrangement that had been operating right under our noses.

When I walked through the door, Daisy was coming down the stairs, the binoculars case slung over her shoulder.

"Well, that was uneventful," she said, handing me the equipment. "The only thing I saw was Tyler hanging around on the street outside smoking a cigarette. He was chatting with Corinne while she took Bluebell out for her late walk. Otherwise, absolutely nothing happened. Most boring neighbourhood watch shift ever."

I nodded, thinking about everything she hadn't seen, couldn't have seen from her front-facing vantage point. Frank and Charlotte entering the house together at the furthest end of the rise, then fucking in the living room while their partners likely did the same in the house opposite. "Maybe that's a good thing," I said. "It means the street is safe."

"True." Daisy stretched, working out the kinks from sitting at the window, pulling her sweater tight over her breasts. "I'm going to make some tea," she said, heading toward the kitchen. "Want some?"

"Sure." I watched her go, looking at how good her ass looked in those tight jeans, thinking about Morgan's parting words. Fuck your wife tonight, but

leave your bedroom curtains open. Someone will be watching.

"I saw Morgan give you a book or something," Daisy called from the kitchen, her voice casual. "What was that?"

The booklet seemed to pulse against my ribs where I'd tucked it inside my jacket. Part of me wanted to read it immediately, to understand exactly what Morgan was offering. But another part of me was terrified of what I might find, and more terrified of how much I might want it.

"Just more neighbourhood watch notes," I said quickly. "Nothing interesting. Procedures and contact numbers, that sort of thing."

"Oh, okay," came her reply. "Put it with the others and I'll have a look at them properly tomorrow."

I headed upstairs, my heart pounding as I made my way to our bedroom. In the privacy of our room, I pulled it out and stared at the cover again: "The Husband's Guide To Wife Sharing, Part 1."

"Do you want some biscuits with the tea?" Daisy called upstairs.

"Yes, please." The implications of what I was holding made my hands shake slightly as I quickly shoved the booklet deep into one of my drawers, burying it beneath a layer of socks. Whatever secrets it contained would have to wait.

The rest of the evening passed as normally as it could. We watched television, shared the leftover crackers that came with the pad thai, talked about Daisy's university work and my meeting with Sarah. Everything felt surreal after what I'd witnessed and learned tonight, but Daisy was completely oblivious, chatting about ordinary things while my mind raced with images of our neighbours' secret lives and thoughts about who had fucked who.

By ten o'clock, Daisy was yawning.

"I'm absolutely shattered," she said, stretching on the sofa. "After last night and today's hangover, I think an early night will do me good."

My pulse quickened. This was it, decision time. Should I try for sex? Should I do what Morgan had suggested? It felt wrong, manipulative somehow, to do this without Daisy's knowledge. But I found myself saying "Me too," and as we headed upstairs and she began getting ready for bed, the opportunity seemed to fall into my lap even further.

She moved around our bedroom as she always did, readying herself for bed, beginning to undress without any thought to the open curtains. After what had happened recently, I should have closed them, but I held back, watching as she pulled her sweater over her head, revealing the lacy white bra underneath.

"You're staring," she said with a smile, reaching behind to unhook the clasp.

"Can you blame me?" I managed, my voice slightly hoarse.

As her bra fell away, revealing her perfect breasts and pert, pink nipples, I glanced toward the window. For a split second, I caught a flash of light from the supposedly empty house at number seventeen, directly opposite our bedroom. Even though it was dark, I was sure I detected movement. Someone was definitely there, watching, probably with binoculars.

The realisation sent a shock of arousal through me. Someone was watching my wife undress. They could see her naked tits.

Daisy noticed my glance toward the window. "Stop being paranoid," she laughed, stepping out of her jeans, so she was just in a pair of matching panties. "No one's watching, Jordan. We did the watch tonight, remember? So, I know it's all clear."

She moved to turn off the main light, and my heart sank. Morgan had specifically said to leave the lights on. But as the room plunged into darkness, I quickly reached for the bedside lamp.

"Leave that on," I said, trying to sound casual. "I want to see your beautiful body."

She smiled at the compliment, standing before me in just her panties, her skin glowing in the soft lamplight. I stripped down to my boxer shorts, acutely aware that whoever was watching from across the street would have a clear view of everything. It felt weird, knowing someone was seeing me in such a state of undress, but I'd come too far to turn back now.

Daisy noticed my obvious arousal, the way my cock strained against the fabric of my shorts.

"Someone's eager tonight," she teased, moving closer to run her hand over the bulge.

Again, the knowledge that someone was watching us from across the street sent a shiver of electricity through every nerve in my body. I felt exposed, vulnerable, but incredibly aroused by it. This was wrong, but I couldn't bring myself to stop.

She hooked her fingers into the waistband of her panties, sliding them down her long legs with deliberate slowness. Standing completely naked in the lamplight, she was breathtaking, her blonde hair catching the warm glow of the bedside lamp, her perfect breasts rising and falling with quickened breathing, the little tuft of blonde hair between her thighs.

"Come here," she whispered, pulling down my boxer shorts. My cock sprang free, already hard and aching with need.

I felt a strange mixture of shame and excitement knowing that whoever was watching could now see everything, my naked wife, my erection, the hungry way we looked at each other. But the shame only intensified the arousal.

Daisy dropped to her knees beside the bed, taking my cock in her mouth without hesitation. Her lips were warm and soft as they wrapped around me, her tongue working magic along my shaft.

"Fuck, Daisy," I groaned, my hands tangling in her hair. I glanced outside at number seventeen, at whoever was watching my wife suck cock. "That feels incredible."

She looked up at me with those brown eyes of hers, my cock still between her lips, and made a soft humming sound that vibrated through me, bringing me surprisingly close to the edge already. "Mmm," she murmured, pulling back to lick along my length. "You taste so good. I love how hard you get for me."

The dirty talk was unexpected, exciting. Daisy wasn't usually this vocal, but I wasn't complaining.

"I want you on the bed," I said, my voice rough with need. "On your hands and knees."

She climbed onto the mattress, positioning herself perfectly in the lamplight and in full view of the window. Her back arched as she looked over her shoulder at me, her blonde hair falling across her face.

"Is this what you want?" she purred. "You want to fuck me from behind?"

I moved behind her, gripping her hips, positioning myself, the head of my cock resting against her slit. She was already wet, ready for me. As I pushed inside her, she let out a long, low moan that filled the room.

"Yes," she gasped. "Oh god, Jordan, yes. Fuck me hard."

I began to move, fucking her hard right away, each thrust making her cry out. The slap of skin against skin, her breathless moans, the way she pushed back against me, it was all being witnessed by someone across the street, and that knowledge drove me to fuck her even harder.

"You feel so good," I groaned, my hands gripping her hips tighter. "So fucking tight."

"Don't stop," she pleaded. "Please don't stop. I'm so close."

Her hand snaked beneath her, finding her clit, her fingers touching the base of my shaft as I pummelled in and out of her.

"I'm going to cum," she cried out, her body beginning to tremble beneath me.

The sight of her orgasm, knowing someone was watching it happen, pushed me over the edge, too. I thrust deep inside her and came hard, my own cries mixing with hers in the lamplight.

Afterwards, we collapsed onto the bed, both of us breathing heavily. Daisy lay on her back beside me, her legs still slightly parted, her body glistening with sweat in the lamplight. From the angle she was lying at, I realised that whoever was watching from number seventeen would have a perfect view of her exposed pussy, still swollen and wet from our lovemaking, maybe leaking my cum.

The reality hit me like a bucket of iced water. Someone had just seen my wife completely naked. Someone had watched us have sex. Someone had witnessed her most intimate moments, the way she'd touched her pussy while I fucked her, the way she looked when she came.

My cock, still semi-hard moments ago, began to wilt as doubt and self-consciousness flooded through me. What had I done? What had I gotten us into? The arousal that had driven me to perform for our hidden audience was rapidly being replaced by something darker, regret, shame, a growing sense that I'd crossed a line I could never uncross.

Morgan's words echoed in my mind: Leave Daisy to me. I've turned conservative women into enthusiastic hotwives before. What did that mean exactly? What would Morgan do now to change Daisy's attitudes toward this lifestyle? How would she approach my wife? Would she manipulate her, seduce her somehow?

"That was incredible," Daisy murmured beside me, still catching her breath. "You were so rough and horny tonight. What got into you?"

I couldn't respond. All I could think about was the watcher across the street, probably still there with binoculars, studying my wife's naked body. Feeling suddenly self-conscious, I reached over and switched off the bedside lamp, plunging the room into darkness.

"Hey," Daisy protested softly. "I was enjoying looking at you. My handsome, modern husband."

"Sorry," I mumbled, pulling the covers up over both of us. "I'm just... tired suddenly."

She curled up against my side, her breathing gradually becoming slower and more regular. Within minutes, I could tell she was drifting toward sleep, her body relaxed and satisfied against mine.

But I lay there wide awake, staring at the ceiling in the darkness, my mind racing with questions and doubts. Had I just made the biggest mistake of my marriage? Was this the beginning of something that would destroy everything Daisy and I had built together? Or was it going to be the start of a new, exciting chapter?

I waited until I was certain she was deeply asleep, her breathing steady and even. Then I carefully slipped out of bed, tiptoeing quietly across the room to the dresser. My hands fumbled in the sock drawer until I found what I was looking for, the booklet Morgan had given me.

Clutching it to my chest, I crept out of the bedroom and down the hall to the bathroom, closing and locking the door behind me. I switched on the light and sat on the edge of the bathtub, my hands trembling slightly as I opened to the first page of *The Husband's Guide To Wife Sharing, Part 1*.

Whatever answers lay within these pages, whatever Morgan's plan was for turning my conservative wife into a willing participant in their secret world, I needed to know. I needed to understand what I'd just set in motion.

And as I began to read, I realised there was no going back.

The Husband's Guide To Wife Sharing, Part 1

Page 1: Introduction

If you're reading this guide, you've likely found yourself in one of two situations: either you've discovered that your quiet suburban neighbourhood harbours secrets you never imagined, or you've been harbouring fantasies of your own that you're finally ready to explore.

This guide exists because conventional marriage advice fails men like you. Men who love their wives deeply but find themselves aroused by the thought of sharing them with others. You're not broken. You're not sick. You're not alone.

For over thirty years, communities like ours have been operating discreetly in suburbs across the country. Successful, respectable couples who've discovered that monogamy, while socially acceptable, isn't the only path to marital fulfilment. These couples have learned that controlled non-monogamy can actually strengthen their relationships, increase intimacy, and provide sexual satisfaction beyond what either partner thought possible.

The Challenge

The biggest obstacle isn't your own desires, it's convincing your partner to embrace what she's been taught to reject. Most women have been conditioned to view wife-sharing as degrading, immoral, or threatening to their marriage. Your wife likely falls into this category. She may have expressed disgust at the very concept, citing moral objections or fear of emotional damage.

This is where most men give up. They assume their fantasies are incompatible with their wives' values and resign themselves to a lifetime of unfulfilled desire.

They're wrong.

The Truth About Women

What these men don't understand is that female sexual desire is far more complex and changeable than most realise. The same wife who recoils at the mention of "swinging" can often be gradually awakened to the excitement of being desired by multiple men, the thrill of sexual variety, and the intoxicating power of being a shared woman.

What This Guide Offers

Over the following pages, you'll learn the proven methods that have successfully converted thousands of reluctant wives into enthusiastic participants. You'll discover how to plant the initial seeds of curiosity without triggering resistance, the psychology behind female sexual awakening, how to leverage social dynamics and peer influence, the role of exhibitionism in overcoming inhibitions and most importantly, you'll learn that this journey isn't about manipulation, it's about unlocking desires your wife already possesses but has been taught to suppress.

Your First Assignment

Before proceeding to Chapter 1, take time to assess your situation honestly. Are you prepared for your wife to potentially desire other men more than she desires you? Can you handle watching her experience pleasure with others that may exceed what you provide?

If the answer is yes, turn the page. Your journey begins now.

Afterword

Well, there you have it, the end of Part One and Jordan's first fateful step into the hidden world of Far Bridge Rise. I hope you enjoyed watching him navigate that impossible moment between desire and doubt, standing at the threshold of a journey that will transform both his marriage and his understanding of himself.

Writing Jordan's story has been an incredible experience, and I'm thrilled you've chosen to come along for the ride. If you enjoyed this volume, Part Two is where things really heat up. Morgan's guide reveals its secrets, Daisy's awakening begins, and Jordan discovers that crossing certain lines changes everything forever.

Thank you for reading, and I'd love to hear your thoughts in a review!

As always, until next time, stay horny!

Paul

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About The Author

Paul Garland is an author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night. He lives with his wife and two children in a small house in the suburbs of Sheffield, England along with a lazy green budgerigar, an African Grey parrot that curses and a tubby tabby cat which would love to eat either. (Preferably the vulgar-tongued parrot.)

He has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his Cerulean Erotica Presents series and No Angels series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began 'The Cuckold Collection,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: The No Angels Stories, The Sexy Season Stories and The Cerulean Archives. 2022 began two series, Holiday Hotwives and A Size Queen Story and 2023 introduced a new series, Improper Investigations and the return to the Cerulean Archives with I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex. 2024 saw the My Wife series and the I Know Who You Did Last Summer series reach huge success and 2025 brings the return of the Detective Hotwife, a new series of sci-fi hotpast erotica and the climax of the Holiday Hotwives books.

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